

Govt notifies permanent winter pollution control guidelines

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has notified a permanent set of winter pollution control guidelines that will automatically come into force every year from November 1 to February 28 without requiring separate annual orders. The measures include a year-round ban on refuelling vehicles without a valid Pollution Under Control certificate, a prohibition on demolition and open civil construction from November 1 to January 31, mandatory 50 per cent work from home for Government and private offices during the same period, and a doubling of parking charges at authorised facilities from November 1 to February 28.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the notification consolidates existing orders into a single enforceable framework. She said Delhi's average Air Quality Index between November 1 and



February 15 ranged from 312 to 342 over the past three years, with maximum AQI levels reaching between 461 and 494, providing the data basis for permanent rather than seasonal intervention. The notification also incorporates the revised Graded Response Action Plan issued by the Commission for Air Quality Management and the Supreme Court directions.

On vehicular pollution, all petrol, diesel, CNG, and LPG stations across Delhi will be required throughout the

year, not just in winter, to supply fuel only to vehicles carrying a valid PUC certificate. Compliance will be verified through the NPR, vehicle database, and electronic systems rather than physical certificates alone. Oil companies, IGL, the Transport Department, MCD, and Delhi Traffic Police will enforce this. From November 1 to January 31 each year, non-Delhi-registered vehicles that do not meet BS-VI emission standards will be barred from entering the city, with exemptions for

CNG, electric, emergency, and police vehicles.

Construction, demolition, and open civil construction that generate dust will be completely prohibited from November 1 to January 31. Finishing work, plumbing, and electrical installations may continue if dust norms are followed. From December 10 to January 20, only essential Government projects will be permitted, and vehicles carrying construction materials, including sand, gravel, stone, bricks, cement, and debris, will not be allowed to enter Delhi during this period.

For large commercial buildings with a built-up area exceeding 3,000 square metres, including malls, hotels, and office buildings of G plus 5 and above, installation of anti-smog guns or mist systems is now mandatory, to be completed by August 15. Construction sites with a plot area exceeding 1,000 square metres must also install mist systems.

CM Rekha Gupta launches Green Drive portal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday launched the Green Drive Portal at greendrive.delhivanmahotsav.in. The portal is a digital platform through which citizens can book plantation slots, request free sapling delivery to their homes or institutions, and register as Green Warriors. The platform was launched ahead of the Ridge Forest Restoration Programme to be formally inaugurated by Union Home Minister Amit Shah in July with a target of planting 70 lakh saplings across the Capital.

The portal was launched at a programme organised by the Department of Environment, Forest and Wildlife. A large number of Delhi Green Warriors attended and pledged to carry the Ek



Ped Maa Ke Naam campaign message to every household.

The portal offers four services at no cost to citizens. The first is plantation slot booking, which allows residents to select a preferred location and time for plantation activities. The second is a Vriksh Rath facility, through which individuals, schools, offices, RWAs, and housing societies

that have space for plantation can request the Delhi Government to deliver free saplings directly to their premises. The third is a nursery locator to help citizens find their nearest Government nursery and collect free saplings. The fourth is an Environment Saviour registration option through which anyone can become a formally registered Green Warrior and remain connected with the Government's environmental initiatives year-round.

On the Ridge Forest Restoration Programme, the Chief Minister said Amit Shah will inaugurate the drive in July and will undertake plantation activities at Ridge locations spanning Delhi from north to south. Under the programme, 70 lakh saplings will be planted across Delhi.

LG urges Police to ensure citizen-centric policing

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Wednesday called upon the Delhi Police to strengthen "visible, humane, technology-driven, and people-centric policing" as the force marked the annual Commissionerate Day with a ceremonial parade at the New Police Lines in Kingsway Camp.

Addressing police personnel after taking the ceremonial salute, Sandhu said the occasion reflected the Delhi Police's evolution into a professional institution since the Commissionerate System was introduced in 1978. He urged the force to remain committed to citizen-centric policing in line with the vision of a developed India. The Lieutenant Governor said ensuring the safety and security of the national Capital



should remain the foremost priority, with special emphasis on women and children. He also lauded initiatives such as Operation Vishwas, under which recovered lost property is returned to citizens, saying such efforts strengthen public confidence in the police.

Generali Central Life Insurance records individual claim settlement ratio at 99.57% in FY26, among the top 5 in the industry

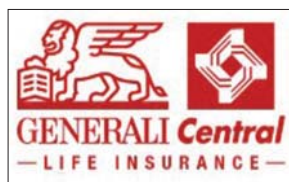
PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Generali Central Life Insurance Co. Ltd, a private leading life insurer, has recorded an individual claim settlement ratio of 99.57% for FY26, a testimony to the trust customers bestow on us. The milestone reflects the Company's continued focus on ensuring timely and dependable claim settlements for policyholders and their families.

Generali Central Life Insurance is a joint venture between global insurance leader Generali and Central Bank of India, combining international expertise with a local banking legacy.

Claim settlement remains one of the most important indicators of trust in the life insurance industry, reflecting an insurer's ability to honour commitments made to policyholders during critical moments.

Over the years, the



Company has focused on simplifying documentation requirements, strengthening digital claim servicing capabilities, and improving turnaround efficiencies to make the claims experience more seamless and accessible for customers. The Company has also continued to strengthen customer support processes with a focus on empathy, responsiveness, and ease of access for claimants during difficult times.

FY26 marked the Company's first full financial year as Generali Central Life Insurance, following the partnership between global insurer Generali and Central Bank of India. Achieving the highest claim settlement performance in the Company's



Mr. Alok Rungta, MD & CEO

history within its first financial year reflects a strong commitment to a customer-first approach.

Commenting on the achievement, Mr. Alok Rungta, MD & CEO, Generali Central Life Insurance, said, "A claim settlement is the ultimate moment of truth for any life insurer. Achieving a 99.57% individual claim settlement ratio in FY26 and being placed among the top five players in

the industry", reflects our sustained efforts towards making the claims experience simpler, faster, and more transparent for policyholders and their families. This milestone is a testament to the collective discipline and quality work across our teams, demonstrating strong co-ordination between Sales, Underwriting, and Claims. We remain committed to being the Lifetime Partner for our customers, because behind every claim is a family that places its trust in us."

The Company also advises policyholders to keep nominee and contact details updated and ensure accurate disclosure at the time of policy purchase to help enable smoother claim processing. Generali Central Life Insurance will continue to further strengthen its claims servicing experience with the aim of making the process as seamless and reassuring as possible for every policyholder's family.

Axis Bank Ltd., Axis House, Tower T-2, 2nd Floor, I-14, Sector-128, Noida Expressway, Jaypee Greens Wishtown, Noida (U.P.)-201301.
Registered Office: Trishul, 3rd Floor Opp. Samartheshwar Temple, Near Law Garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad - 380006

Appendix IV [Refer Rule - 8(1)] Possession Notice (For Immovable Property)
Whereas The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Axis Bank Ltd. under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13 (12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued demand notice dated 06-Aug-2025 calling upon MR. SANJAY KUMAR & MRS. ANSHU SHARMA (Borrower/Co-Borrower/Mortgagor/Guarantor) to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being Rs. 3,44,008/- (Rupees Three Lakhs Four Thousand Eight Only) due as on 31-Jul-2025 and interest and cost thereon within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagor(s)/Guarantor(s) above said having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagor(s)/Guarantor(s) and the Public in General that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under Section 13 (4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 on 29-06-2026. The Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagor(s)/Guarantor(s) above said in particular and the Public in General is hereby cautioned not to deal with the properties and any dealings with the properties will be subject to the charge of the Axis Bank Ltd. for an amount of Rs. 3,44,008/- (Rupees Three Lakhs Four Thousand Eight Only) as on 31-Jul-2025 together with further interest thereon at the contractual rate of interest till the date of payment & expenses thereon. The Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagor(s)/Guarantor(s) attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Description of immovable property All that part and parcel of Property bearing:

All that part and parcel of Flat No. 1003, T3 Gulmohar Garden, Rajnagar, Extension, Ghaziabad, 201001. Please note that as mention in sub Section 13 of Section 13 of the aforesaid act, you shall not transfer by way of sale, lease or otherwise any of the assets stated under security referred to in this notice without prior written consent of our bank.

Date: 29-06-2026, Place: GHAZIABAD Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.

DELHI TRANSCO LIMITED

NOTICE INVITING e - TENDER

Delhi Transco Ltd, a Government of NCT of Delhi Undertaking, intends to invite following online Two Part Domestic Competitive Bidding (DCB) Tender for the following works:

Tender No. T25P640001: Augmentation of 02 Nos 500 MVA ICT along with associated equipment & accessories including civil work at 400 kV Substation Harsh Vihar & 400 kV Bawana on Turnkey basis.

For complete details of the tender please visit following websites:-
<https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in> (Tender ID No. 2026_DTL_294614_1) and www.dtl.gov.in with Unique ID No. DTL-0070-010726

Last date for bid submission:- **18.08.2026, 01:30 P.M.**

All Corrigendum/Addendum/ Amendments/Date of Extension/Clarifications etc. to this e-tender will be hosted on the above website only. Bidders should regularly visit website to keep themselves updated.

NORTHERN RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE

The Chief Engineer/Const./RSP/NR, 901 B, Tower-1, 9th Floor, Konnectus Tower, DMRC Building, Ajmeri Gate, New Delhi-110002 for and on behalf of the President of India invites e-tender under Two Packet System for the under noted work:-

1. Full Name of Work	Construction of 4 ROB's (i) 2 lane ROB in lieu of LC- C-28 at KM. 18/1-2 on Jalandhar Cantt- Hoshiarpur section of Firozpur Division (ii) 2 lane ROB in lieu of LC-48 at KM. 71.461 on Bathinda - Shri Ganganagar section of Ambala Division (iii) 2 lane ROB in lieu of LC-B-20 at KM. 28/0-1 on Bathinda -Sriganganagar section of Ambala Division (iv) 2 lane ROB in lieu of LC-58 at KM.86.541 on Bathinda -Sriganganagar section of Ambala Division (including LHS) of Northern Railway under the Road Safety Projects Unit (RSPU)/NR New Delhi.
2. Approx. Cost of work	Rs 1,96,02,44,048.11/- Rupees Only (One Hundred Ninety-Six Crore Two Lakh Forty Four Thousand Forty-Eight Rupees and Eleven Paise Only.)
3. Completion period of the works	18 months Period
4. Earnest Money to be deposited	3,92,04,900.00/- Rupees only (Three Crore Ninety-Two Lakh Four Thousand Nine Hundred Rupees Only.)
5. Sale/availability of tender document on Rly. Website	Tender documents will be available on IREPS web site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in from 30.06.2026 to 24.07.2026.
6. Last date/Time of upload of tenders	Tender documents can be uploaded on IREPS website upto 24-07-2026, 11:30 hrs.
7. Date and time of opening of tender	[Any time after 24.07.2026, 11:30 hrs.
8. Pre bid Conference	Date: 07.07.2026 Time: 12:00 Hrs to 13:00 Hrs. Venue: Office of CAO/CRSP 9th Floor Konnectus Tower, DMRC Building, Ajmeri Gate, New Delhi-110002 and through online VC link (uploaded on IREPS).

No. 26-W-09-2026-WA-DyCE-C-RSP Dated: 30.06.2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 2246/26

सेंट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया
Central Bank of India

1911 से आपके लिए "केंद्रित" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911

Regional Office Delhi (North) 1398, First Floor, Chandni Chowk, Delhi-110006

CORRIGENDUM

Please refer to the advertisement of "E-Auction Sale Notice" (to be held on 20.07.2026) published in this newspaper on 01.07.2026. The Branch Name for Sl. No. 6 – M/s Kartkey Trading Co. and Sl. No. 7 – Prem Pal Bhardwaj should be read as "GHONDA Branch" instead of "Ghaziabad Branch". All other details shall remain unchanged.

Sd/- Authorised Officer, Central Bank of India

e-Tender is invited by Principal Chief Engineer, Metro Railway for the following work: **Name of work:** Providing & fixing sheet piles along the Tolly nala from entrance stair (Gate No. 2) towards KKNZ and construction of retaining wall to retain the filled earth etc., fencing over the wall and allied works in place damaged existing arrangement of rail & brickwork at KSKD in East Section (Blue Line) of Metro Railway, Kolkata. **Approx. Cost of Work:** Rs. 99,52,102.33, **Earnest Money:** Rs. 1,93,100/-, **Completion Period:** 09 (Nine) Months, **Date and Time of Closing:** 24.07.2026 at 12:00 Hrs. The Tender Document and other details can be obtained from the website www.ireps.gov.in in Amendments/Corrigendum, if any, would be uploaded only on the website.

Abridged e-Tender Notice No. : Civil-2571-2026(Open)

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OFFICE OF THE RETURNING OFFICER

FARMTRADE AGRO MULTI-STATE MARKETING CO-OPERATIVE LIMITED

B-11/05 DLF PHASE 1 SECTOR -26 GURUGRAM

Ph No.:+91-9467532220 Website: farmcoagro.com/

Ref. No.: FAMCO/ELECTION/2026-27/001

01st JULY, 2026

In exercise of the power conferred by Section 45K (3) (b) of the Multi-State Cooperative Societies Act (MSCS), Act 2002, read with rule 19F (a) of MSCS Rules 2002, the Cooperative Election Authority vide his letter No. CEA-12011/379/2025 dated 5th June 2026 appoints Deputy Commissioner, Gurugram as Returning officer and Deputy Commissioner, Gurugram further Appoints Mr. Trilok Singh Chhattha (Assistant registrar, cooperative Societies, Gurugram) as ARO (Assistant Returning officer) vide letter No. 2589 dated 26/06/2026 for conducting election of the FARMTRADE AGRO MULTI-STATE MARKETING CO-OPERATIVE LIMITED (FAMCO) B11/05 DLF PHASE 1 SECTOR - 26 GURUGRAM-122022. Henceby call for a Special General Body Meeting of aforesaid Society on 2nd August 2026 at 8:00 AM to 4:00 PM at the premises of ARO CIVIL LINE for the conduct of election of six (7) Directors of the Society (Four from the General Category, two Women Directors, and one SC/ST Director) and 2 office bearers (Chairman - 1 and Vice-Chairman - 1).

(A) Election Program for Board of Directors				
S. No.	Particular	Date	Time	Venue
1	Publication of Provisional List of Members' eligible to vote	29th June, 2026 (Monday)	By Evening	Society notice board, Website and Office of Assistant Registrar Cooperative Societies, Civil Lines, Gurugram
2	Time Window for Raising Objection to the Provisional List	30th June to 03rd July 2026 (Tuesday to Friday)	11:00 AM to 3:00 PM	Office of Assistant Registrar Co-operative societies, civil lines, Gurugram
3	Scrutiny of objection received to the Provisional List (if any)	06th July, 2026 (Monday)	11:00 AM to 3:00 PM	Office of Assistant Registrar Co-operative societies, civil lines, Gurugram
4	Publication of Final List of Members' Eligible to Vote	06th July, 2026 (Monday)	By Evening	Society notice board, Website and Office of Assistant Registrar Cooperative Societies, Civil Lines, Gurugram
5	Issue and Filing of Nomination Form	13th July to 16th July, 2026 (Monday to Thursday)	11:00 AM to 3:00 PM	Office of Assistant Registrar Co-operative societies, civil lines, Gurugram
6	Publication of List of Nominations Received	16th July, 2026 (Thursday)	By Evening	Society notice board, Website and Office of Assistant Registrar Cooperative Societies, Civil Lines, Gurugram
7	Scrutiny of received Nomination Forms	17th July, 2026 (Friday)	11:00 AM onward	Office of Assistant Registrar Co-operative societies, civil lines, Gurugram
8	Publication of list of Valid Nominations	17th July, 2026 (Friday)	By Evening	Society notice board, Website and Office of Assistant Registrar Cooperative Societies, Civil Lines, Gurugram
9	Withdrawal of Nominations	20th July, 2026 (Monday)	11:00 AM to 3:00 PM	Office of Assistant Registrar Co-operative societies, civil lines, Gurugram
10	Publication of Final list of Contesting Candidates	20th July, 2026 (Monday)	By Evening	Society notice board, Website and Office of Assistant Registrar Cooperative Societies, Civil Lines, Gurugram
11	Date of Polling, if Necessary	02nd August, 2026 (Monday)	8:00 AM to 04:00 PM and all those who have entered polling station at 04 PM or before should be allowed to cast vote	Office of Assistant Registrar Co-operative societies, civil lines, Gurugram
12	Counting of votes	03rd August, 2026 (Monday)	08:00 AM Onwards	Society notice board, Website and Office of Assistant Registrar Cooperative Societies, Civil Lines, Gurugram
13	Submission of form 19M with recommendations for seeking approval of CEA before declaration of result of BOD	03rd August, 2026 (Monday)	-	B11/05 DLF Phase 1 Sector 26 Gurugram
14	Declaration of Result of Board of Directors	On or before 10th August, 2026 (Monday)	-	Office of Assistant Registrar Co-operative societies, civil lines, Gurugram
(B) Election Program of Office Bearers				
1	Announcement of Election Schedule I. Time window for filing Nomination II. Scrutiny of nomination paper III. Time window and date for withdrawal IV. Display of list of the contesting candidate and schedule of elections	17th August, 2026 (Monday)	09:30 AM to 11:30 AM 12:30 PM to 02:00 PM 02:00 PM to 04:00 PM By Evening	B11/05 DLF Phase 1 Sector - 26 Gurugram
2	Meeting of Newly constituted list for valid nomination, Polling (if required)	18th August, 2026 (Tuesday)	11 AM Onwards	B11/05 DLF Phase 1 Sector - 26 Gurugram
3	Declaration of result of Election of office Bearers	After approval of Cooperative Election Authority, New Delhi on format 19N		

In this connection you are requested to please send the nomination form for the election of the Board of Directors of Farmtrade Agro Multistate Marketing Cooperative Limited by 16th July 2026 upto 3 PM by hand or Registered Post at the Society's address - B-11/5, DLF Phase 1 SECTOR-26, Gurugram.

The nominations received after above mentioned date and time shall not be entertained and thereafter he/she will not be eligible to participate in the election process.

This issues with the approval of Cooperative Election Authority.

(Mr. Trilok Singh Chhattha)
Assistant Returning Officer

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of SAMEER who is acquiring Property bearing No. C-83/2, area measuring 83.61 sq. mtrs. i.e. 100 sq. yds., comprised in Kharsa No. 668/474/65, situated at village Mauipur, in the estate of Gail No. 7, Mohanpur, Mauipur, Ilaga Shahdara, Delhi-110032 from his mother Mrs. Shamsheer w/o Mohd. Rizwan on the basis of a proposed Regd. Gift Deed which to be duly registered with the concerned SRO, previously Mrs. Shamsheer w/o Mohd. Rizwan had owned the subject property from Mr. Jalaluddin s/o Insan Shanki vide Regd. General Power of Attorney dated 26.10.2024. Document No. 2024/231V/2059, in Book No. IV/A, Volume No. 1254 Page No.83-94 on this dated 29.10.2024. SRO-IV/A, Shahdara, New Delhi/ Delhi (read with Agreement to Sell and Will), after execution of proposed Regd. Gift Deed Mr. SAMEER shall be owner of the subject property and the subject property to be mortgaged with VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LTD So. to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC. We give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances. **Lucan Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar, Near Yusuf Sarai Community New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-44046316 & 41667327**

PUBLIC NOTICE

My client, Mr. Sandeep Sethi S/o Mr. Prem Prakash Sethi R/o Flat No-1503, Tower-2, M3M Skywalk, Sector-74, Gurugram, Haryana, has disowned and debarred his wife Mini Sethi, son Siddharth Sethi and daughter Simran Sethi from all his movable and immovable properties. My client shall not be liable for any act, transaction or liability incurred by them.

Sachin Kumar (Advocate)
RU-6, Pitampura, Delhi

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is hereby notified for the information of the general public on behalf of my clients Sh. Kuldeep Singh Makkar S/o Trilok Singh and Smt. Sharan Jeet Karar Makkar W/o Kuldeep Singh Makkar both R/o C-4F/209, Near So. to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC. We give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances. **Lucan Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar, Near Yusuf Sarai Community New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-44046316 & 41667327**

Public Notice

This is to inform the general public that Mr. Jagdish Prasad is the GPA Holder of Property No. 88, area measuring 30 Sq. Yds. Of 4th Floor Kharsa No. 222 situated in the Village Hastali, District Delhi, Area Abadi colony known Vikas Nagar, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059. He is in Possession through Notarized GPA, ATS & Will Dated 13.02.2026 executed by Mrs. Dropti in favour of Mr. Jagdish Prasad in respect of property No. 88, area measuring 30 Sq. Yds. Out of Kharsa No. 222. Mr. Jagdish Prasad has hereby transferred the ownership of above said Property by way of Sale Deed to Mr. Moti Lal and Ritik. Subsequently, Mr. Moti Lal and Ritik are in the process of mortgaging the said property with SFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7-day period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.

If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 7-day period by contacting Law Veritas - North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at No. 11, 1st floor, Building A-14A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh (201301); Landline(s): +9102-04499711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

PUBLIC NOTICE

Mr. Suchanshu Singh has approached (ICICI Bank Ltd., Ghaziabad, U.P. (Bank) to avail a Loan for purchase of Property No. 3/24, (297.19 sq. mtrs.), Block-3, Sector-5, T.H.A., Rajender Nagar, Ghaziabad, U.P. (property) from Mrs. Shobha Gupta, who has represented that she is the absolute owner of the said property by virtue of Sale Deed dated 24.01.2023 (Doc. No. 389) executed by Mrs. Asha. She has further represented that the Transfer/Sale deed registered on 01.07.1987 (Doc. No. 12071), Allotment Letter, Possession Letter have been misplaced/lost and FIR/GD No. 067 dated 17.09.2022 has been lodged with P.S. Sahibabad, Ghaziabad. If anybody, person, body corporate has any right, lien or claim whatsoever on the said Property by way of inheritance, mortgage, sale, or on the basis of lost documents or otherwise, then he/she/it may contact the undersigned with documentary proof of claim within 07 days of publication of this notice, otherwise it shall be deemed that either there are no claims or the same have been waived off. No claim or objection shall be entertained thereafter and Bank shall proceed to advance the loan on mortgaging of the said property.

Amit Kumar, Advocate
Narang & Associates
D-28, Jangpura Extension,
New Delhi-110014.

Office of the Superintending Engineer

6th circle, P.W.D. Uttarkashi

Website- <http://pwd.uk.gov.in> E-Mail : sepwduki@rediffmail.com

Letter No.- 2746/56 M-06/2026 **National competitive bid (E-Tendering)** Date 30.06.2026

On behalf of the Hon'ble Governor of Uttarakhand, Superintending Engineer 6th circle, PWD Uttarkashi invites item rate tender through e-tendering (Two bid system) for the following work. All the information regarding tender shall be available on website <http://www.uktenders.gov.in> from dated 03.07.2026 at 05:00 PM.

Sl. N.	Name of work	Earnest money (In Lacs)	Tender Cost (in Rupees)	Validity of tender (days)	Completion period (Month)	Contractor's Category of registration
1	New construction work of extension of Margaon Jaspur Chamiyari Ulan motor road from km 16 to 19 constituency Yamunotri of District Uttarkashi under state sector.	4.04	5000.00 + 18% GST	90	12	Road work registration in C or higher category in PWD Uttarakhand

Delhi likely to get monsoon in two days: Met department

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi is likely to receive the south-west monsoon within the next two days, ending a prolonged wait and offering respite from the lingering summer heat. The arrival will mark the latest monsoon onset over the national Capital in five years.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), conditions are favourable for the further advance of the southwest monsoon into more parts of the north Arabian Sea, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, Chandigarh, Delhi, Punjab and parts of Rajasthan during the next two days.

According to the IMD, the south-west monsoon reached Delhi on

June 25, 2020, a day before it covered the entire country on June 26. In 2021, the monsoon arrived much later, reaching Delhi on July 13, the same day it covered the entire country.

In 2022, the monsoon advanced over Delhi on June 30 and covered the entire country on July 2. It reached the national Capital on June 25, 2023, while the entire country came under monsoon conditions by July 2. In 2024, the monsoon arrived in Delhi on June 28 and covered the whole country on July 2. Last year, the southwest monsoon reached Delhi on June 29, the same day it completed its advance over the entire country.

The IMD has forecast a generally cloudy sky with moderate rain for Delhi on Wednesday night and issued a yellow alert. Similar



weather conditions are expected on Thursday. The maximum temperature is likely to settle around 33 degrees Celsius, while the minimum temperature is expected to be around 23 degrees Celsius.

No measurable rainfall was recorded between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm at any of Delhi's five weather stations on Wednesday. However, the 24-hour cumulative rainfall till 8.30 am was recorded as a trace at Safdarjung, Palam and Ayanagar. Ridge recorded 0.2 mm of rainfall, while Lodhi Road recorded none.

The maximum temperature ranged between 33.2 degrees Celsius and 34.8 degrees Celsius, remaining below normal across all five IMD stations.

Safdarjung, the city's base station, recorded a maximum

temperature of 34.8 degrees Celsius, 2.6 degrees below normal. Palam recorded 33.6 degrees Celsius, 4.2 degrees below normal, while Lodhi Road recorded 33.7 degrees Celsius, 3.3 degrees below normal. Ridge and Ayanagar both recorded 33.2 degrees Celsius, which was 3.5 degrees and 4.9 degrees below normal, respectively.

The minimum temperature varied across the city, with Safdarjung recording 28.6 degrees Celsius, 0.7 degrees above normal. Palam recorded 26 degrees Celsius, 1.8 degrees below normal, while Lodhi Road recorded 28 degrees Celsius, one degree above normal. Ridge recorded the lowest minimum temperature at 24.5 degrees Celsius, one degree below normal, and Ayanagar recorded

27.4 degrees Celsius, 0.6 degrees above normal.

Humidity levels continued to rise ahead of the expected monsoon onset, with the relative humidity recorded at 75 per cent at 8.30 am and 62 per cent at 5.30 pm.

Explaining the delay, Mahesh Palawat, Vice President, Skymet Weather, said the humid easterly winds from the Bay of Bengal, which are essential for sustained monsoon rainfall, have not yet reached Delhi.

He said the seasonal trough acts as the backbone of the southwest monsoon. It is an elongated zone of low atmospheric pressure that draws moisture-laden winds from the Arabian Sea and the Bay of Bengal deep into the Indian mainland, helping organise widespread rainfall.

Rock carvings discovered in Delhi's Central Ridge

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

What began as a routine visit to document the biodiversity of Delhi's Central Ridge led two environmentalists to an unexpected discovery, a set of rock carvings etched into a quartzite outcrop near the Polo Ground that experts say require detailed scientific study before their age or significance can be determined.

The carvings were noticed by environmentalists Pradip Krishen and Chetan Agarwal during one of their regular visits to the Ridge, where they usually document the area's rich biodiversity and plant life.

Krishen said the two had visited the spot several times before, but it was during a recent visit that Agarwal noticed unusual markings on a large quartzite rock protruding from the ground near the Polo Ground.

"The discovery itself was accidental. We were there to study the Ridge's biodiversity, not to look for archaeological remains. Chetan



Central Ridge

noticed the carvings, which intrigued us. We later brought along a historian friend, who suggested that they could possibly be petroglyphs," he said.

Petroglyphs are ancient symbolic images or figures carved or scratched on rock surfaces. Krishen said he was not an expert on petroglyphs and therefore could not speculate on the age of the carvings.

"At some sites, we have a way of establishing a minimum age for petroglyphs. For example, where Ashokan rock edicts have been carved over older rock carvings, we know the pet-

roglyphs cannot be younger than the edicts, which date to the third century BC," he said.

He added that it is difficult to say exactly how old the petroglyphs are. "They could be a thousand years older, 500 years older, 200 years older, or even just a year older. But at least we know they are not younger than the edict," he said.

He further added that in this case, however, they don't have any such comparative evidence. All that is visible is that the carvings are extremely eroded.

"They are on quartzite, which is an extremely hard

rock, so it takes a very long time for marks on it to weather and fade. To my untrained eyes, the carvings certainly look extremely old, but I am not an expert on petroglyphs, so I cannot express an opinion on their age," Krishen said.

He added that the carvings are on a large quartzite rock protruding from the ground in the Central Ridge, near the Polo Ground.

Krishen said the markings appeared to comprise two distinct patterns. One resembled a row of seven or eight cup-like depressions, or cupules, arranged parallel to one another.

The other resembled two ladder-like figures set at right angles. He said one possibility was that it may have been used as a game board, although it could equally have been a decorative motif. He stressed that these were only personal observations and not archaeological conclusions.

Experts said that even though it is possible for the carvings to be ancient, they urged caution against assigning any age or historical significance to the

markings without scientific investigation.

"The Aravalis are among the oldest mountain ranges in the world, so finding rock carvings here is not unusual. Similar carvings have been reported earlier by the Haryana Government and researchers, including Dr AK Sharma," said archaeologist Dr Sanjeev Kumar Singh.

Singh added that, however, such discoveries cannot be assigned an age or historical significance immediately. They require detailed archaeological investigation, scientific study and discussions among experts before any conclusions can be drawn.

He added that at this stage, these carvings are a matter of academic discussion. While they could be significant, it would be premature to speculate on their age or origin without proper evidence. For now, the carvings remain an intriguing find whose age, purpose and historical context can only be established through detailed archaeological documentation and scientific analysis.

Delhi Police bust prostitution racket at spa, 1 arrested

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A spa on busy Panchkuian Road in central Delhi was allegedly operating as a front for a prostitution racket until a decoy customer, armed with pre-recorded currency notes, entered the premises. The police raid that followed led to the arrest of the owner-cum-manager and the rescue of four women on Wednesday.

Acting on a tip-off received on June 30, the Paharganj police laid a trap by sending a decoy customer into the spa with pre-recorded ₹2,000 currency notes. According to police, the spa operator allegedly offered sexual services to the decoy, accepted the advance payment and directed one of the women present at the premises to accompany him to a room.

After receiving the predetermined signal from the decoy, the raiding team entered the spa and apprehended the accused on the spot. In the search that followed, police recovered ₹3,400 in cash, including the decoy money, a customer entry register, and other material allegedly linked to the illegal operation.

The arrested accused was identified as Ajay Malhotra (39), a resident of Multani Dhanda in Nabi Karim, who allegedly owned and managed the spa.



During interrogation, Malhotra allegedly admitted to operating the establishment and facilitating prostitution under the guise of spa services, police said. Investigators are also probing whether other persons were involved in running the alleged racket.

An FIR has been registered at Paharganj police station under Sections 3, 4 and 5 of the Immoral Traffic (Prevention) Act, 1956, and further investigation is underway. Police said they rescued four women during the operation.

"The operation was carried out based on credible secret information. A carefully planned decoy operation confirmed the illegal activities, after which the accused was arrested

and incriminating material was seized. Further investigation is underway to identify others connected with the racket," said Rohit Rajbir Singh, Deputy Commissioner of Police, Central District.

The raid was carried out by a team led by women officers, along with other personnel from Paharganj police station, under the supervision of senior officers.

A similar incident occurred on June 12, when police busted a sex racket operating inside a rented property in the Qutub Area in Paharganj. In that case, the police arrested one accused, Shahrukh, who was allegedly operating the racket. Additionally, authorities also rescued four women.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) examining the constitutional framework for simultaneous elections visited the Delhi Assembly on Wednesday. The visit is a part of nationwide consultations. Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta interacted with the committee members and called for comprehensive examination of issues including constructive votes of no-confidence, premature dissolution of legislatures, and harmonisation of electoral rolls, while emphasising that any reform must rest on broad political consensus and robust constitutional safeguards.

The committee is examining the Constitution (One Hundred and Twenty-Ninth Amendment) Bill, 2024, and the Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2024, which together form the legislative framework for One Nation, One Election. The panel is headed by its Chairperson, PP Chaudhary, and is engaging



with State Governments, constitutional authorities, political parties, and other stakeholders across the country before submitting its recommendations to Parliament.

Earlier, the panel held discussions with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and ministers of the Delhi Government at the Secretariat. During the meeting, the Committee held detailed discussions with the Chief Minister on the constitutional, legal and administrative aspects of the two Amendment Bills. The deliberations covered a range of issues, including synchronisa-

tion of Lok Sabha and Assembly elections, integration of the electoral cycle, the likely impact on the Government of National Capital Territory of Delhi Act, and administrative preparedness. She said that holding simultaneous elections across the country is the need of the hour and that there could be no better arrangement. The Chief Minister said the Delhi Government supports every reform that strengthens good governance, administrative efficiency and the democratic system. At the same time, she emphasised that any such

reform must fully preserve the spirit of the Constitution and democratic principles.

During the interaction, Chaudhary described the committee's work as an exercise with far-reaching implications for India's democratic and electoral architecture. He said the consultative process across the country was designed to ensure that the committee's final recommendations reflect the full range of India's constitutional, political, and federal perspectives. "The consultative process would enable the Committee to present a comprehensive and well-informed report to Parliament," he said.

Speaking during his interaction with the committee, Speaker Vijender Gupta traced the historical context of the proposal. He noted that simultaneous elections were the norm in the initial decades after Independence but that political developments and premature dissolutions of legislatures gradually led to divergent electoral cycles across States and the Centre.

Delhi notifies EV Policy 2026; subsidies within 60 days

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Buyers of electric vehicles (EVs) in Delhi will receive subsidies within 60 days of applying for an incentive on their purchase, including two-wheelers priced up to ₹2.25 lakh, as outlined in the new EV Policy, notified on Wednesday. All purchase incentives for electric two-wheelers, three-wheelers (autos), and four-wheeled goods vehicles that are purchased and registered in Delhi will be disbursed through direct benefit transfers to individual buyers, proprietary firms, agencies, and companies that are residents of Delhi only.

"...In exercise of the powers conferred by the enabling provisions of the Motor Vehicles Act, 1988, and the rules made thereunder, the Lieutenant Governor of the National Capital Territory of



Delhi hereby notifies the Delhi Electric Vehicles Policy, 2026 with effect from July 1, 2026," the notification states.

As per the notification, a Model Approval Committee constituted under the Transport Department of the Delhi Government will be responsible for the empanelment of EV models across eligible vehicle segments for

availing incentives and subsidies under the policy notified on Tuesday.

The committee will examine and approve vehicle models based on the eligibility criteria, technical specifications, and other conditions prescribed under the operational guidelines, as stated in the notification of the Delhi EV Policy, 2026.

SINGLE-WINDOW CLEARANCE FOR CHARGING FACILITIES

New Delhi: Buyers of electric vehicles in Delhi could get quicker access to charging and battery-swapping facilities through a single-window clearance system for faster approvals, while RWAs and housing societies are encouraged to install chargers under the new EV policy.

According to the EV policy notified by the Government on Wednesday, EV buyers will also be able to access charging facilities at dealerships, as every Original Equipment Manufacturer (OEM) operating in Delhi has to deploy at least one public charging station at each dealer with a minimum of three charging points for two- and three-wheelers and two charging points for four-wheelers.

The Delhi Government will seek financial support under the Centre's PM E-Drive scheme and other Government of India schemes to expand public and community EV charging and battery-swapping infrastructure, while also allocating funds to the power department, according to the Delhi Electric Vehicle Policy 2026. To improve charging efficiency, DISCOMs will explore Energy Storage Systems (ESS) at electric bus depots for load management and grid reliability.

"They will also examine time-of-day tariffs and differential electricity pricing through the Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission to reduce charging costs," the policy said.

Massive fire guts Vijay Sales showroom in Uttam Nagar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A massive fire ripped through a multi-storey Vijay Sales electronics showroom in Delhi's Uttam Nagar early Wednesday, destroying stock worth several lakhs. No injuries or fatalities were reported, Delhi Fire Service (DFS) officials said.

The blaze broke out near Metro Pillar 663 around 4:15 am. Visuals from the spot showed towering flames and thick black smoke billowing into the sky as the fire rapidly spread through the building, which was visible from a considerable distance.

According to Rajendra Atwal, DFS Public Relations Officer, nine fire tenders were initially rushed to the scene. As the blaze intensi-



A massive fire broke out at multi-storey Vijay Sales electronics showroom, destroying all the electrical goods at Uttam Nagar, New Delhi on Wednesday

PANKAJ KUMAR

fied, additional fire engines were deployed to contain it. The showroom had a basement, a ground floor and three upper floors. It had also expanded into the third and fourth floors of an adjacent building above a Bata showroom, with access through the Vijay Sales premises.

Preliminary investigations suggest the fire

started on the third floor and rapidly spread through the structure. The flames also gutted the third and fourth floors of the adjoining building occupied by the showroom. Firefighters battled it for nearly two hours and extinguished it by about 6:30 am. Cooling operations and searches for any remaining hotspots continued until noon.

IN FOCUS



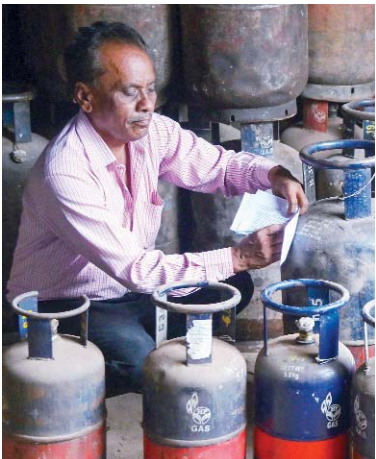
Vijay Kumar Sharma, popularly known as the Monkey Man of Jaipur, feeds fruits to monkeys near the Galtaji Temple in Jaipur Rajasthan PTI

Commercial LPG cylinder prices cut; no relief for domestic consumers

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

With tensions abating in West Asia consumers in India got major relief due to cuts in the prices of commercial LPG and Chotu cylinders while Households, however, will have to wait.

Oil-marketing companies have reduced the prices of the commercial variant of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) cylinders by an average of ₹180 per cylinder and that of the five-kg free trade LPG (FTL) cylinders by approximately ₹13 per cylinder. In addition to this, prices of aviation turbine fuel (ATF) for domestic scheduled carriers have been slashed by ₹5 per litre to ₹110 per litre. Other than LPG, privately owned oil marketing company Nayara Energy – which operates more than 7,000 pumps across the country – also reduced the price of petrol and diesel by ₹5 per litre and ₹3 per litre respectively. State-owned Indian Oil Corp (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corp Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corp Ltd (HPCL), which together account for more than 90 per cent of India's fuel retail market, left prices unchanged. In Delhi, IOC continues to sell petrol at ₹102.12 per litre and diesel at ₹95.20 per litre. The BJP on Wednesday welcomed the



reduction in commercial LPG prices, saying the decision reflects the Modi Government 's commitment to protecting citizens' interests despite global uncertainties.

The 19 kg cylinder in Delhi – which also serves as the benchmark for prices in the country – became cheaper by ₹183.5 to ₹2,930 per cylinder. Further, the price of the five-kg free trade LPG cylinder refills – primarily catering to migrant labourers – now stands at ₹808.5 per cylinder with the latest reduction.

Along largely similar lines, Mumbai woke up to prices of the 19-kg cylinder being reduced by ₹182

per cylinder to ₹2,885 per cylinder. Prices in Kolkata have been reduced by ₹174 to ₹3081.5 per cylinder. Chennai too witnessed a ₹177 reduction in prices with the 19 kg cylinder now being sold at ₹3,106 per cylinder. Prices of domestic 14.2-kg LPG cylinders were left unchanged at ₹942.

The latest revision marks the first reduction in commercial LPG prices this year. It comes after commercial users faced successive price increases over the past few months as global LPG markets were rattled by supply concerns linked to the conflict in the Middle East. The reduction is expected to lower operating costs for businesses that depend heavily on commercial LPG, including restaurants, hotels, roadside eateries and catering services.

Wednesday's price cut comes after four tranches of hikes that saw the price of commercial LPG cumulatively increase to ₹1,345 per cylinder since March 7.

Further, the fall in commercial LPG prices comes in nearly a week after the Union Petroleum Ministry on June 25 restored the supply of industrial and commercial LPG to pre-crisis levels and withdrew all sector-specific allocations, citing an improved supply situation.

Delhi Jal Board to install 47 piezometers to track groundwater

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Delhi Jal Board (DJB) plans to install 47 piezometers across the city to monitor groundwater, officials said on Wednesday.

Earlier, the Delhi Government had announced a tubewell policy under which groundwater extraction would rise. "The piezometers are basically monitoring wells dug up in the ground to measure the quantity and quality of water. The work will be implemented in around four months after award of work, for which we have floated a tender," a DJB official said.

In April, during the 'Catch the Rain' event organised by the DJB as part of the rainwater harvesting programme, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said that the Delhi Government is planning to bring a borewell policy in the city to ease water shortage problems.

"The Delhi Government is seriously considering bringing in a borewell policy. But



only those houses and residential colonies which have a proper functioning water harvesting system will be eligible to get an authorised borewell," Gupta had said.

According to officials, with limited sources of water supply of its own, the national capital's dependency on groundwater is likely to increase in the future, for which a new borewell policy is needed.

The DJB currently operates 10 water treatment plants (WTPs) producing around 990-1000 million gallons per day (MGD) of water, which includes 135 MGD from tubewells.

TN factory ammonia gas leak: Death toll increases to 17

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Chennai

The death toll in the ammonia gas leak at a private seafood processing and export facility in Tamil Nadu's Tiruvallur district increased to 17 on Wednesday, the Government said.

The Health Department, in a release, said that all the deceased were women. While 14 of them are from Odisha, two were from Assam and one hailed from Jharkhand. The toxic industrial chemical leak occurred during routine industrial operations on June 21, at the facility located in the Kannigaipair/Manjungarai area near Periyapalayam.



A total of 83 persons have been reported as affected by the incident. Of these 15 persons, all women, were currently receiving treatment and

are under medical observation, the release further added. Mortal remains of the victims were airlifted to their respective native states.

TVK alliance meeting charts three-point roadmap

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Chennai

In a major move to strengthen political ties, a crucial TVK alliance meeting on Wednesday chalked out a three-stage framework, including the constitution of a dedicated coordination committee in the future.

The ruling TVK on Wednesday held its first meeting with alliance partners - the Congress, VCK and IUML - which are part of the coalition Government .

The meeting, chaired by Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam founder and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay, was attended by Tamil Nadu Congress Committee president and MP B Manickam Tagore, senior Congress leader P Chidambaram, VCK chief Thol Thirumavalavan, MDMK leader Vaiko, IUML president KM Kader Mohideen, and senior TVK party functionaries and ministers.

However, leaders of the Left parties skipped the meeting, citing that they were providing only outside support to the Government. Speaking to reporters



Chennai: Tamil Nadu Chief Minister and Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) chief C Joseph Vijay, Tamil Nadu Congress Committee president and MP B Manickam Tagore, senior Congress leader P Chidambaram, VCK chief Thol Thirumavalavan and others in Kovalam, near Chennai PTI

soon after the meeting, Tamil Nadu Congress chief Manickam Tagore said that to propel the alliance forward, party leaders had deliberated extensively on three core agendas: establishing a dedicated coordination committee, drafting a common minimum agenda, and

finalising an official name for the coalition. Stating that all participating leaders had actively exchanged views during the consultation meeting, he said, "The final decision on all three agendas will be taken in the next meeting, which is scheduled to be held very shortly."

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transfer of money from the collection boxes to the counting team. Some evidence suggests bank staff handling cash may also be involved. Reports suggest that being close to powerful people in, or connected to, the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust enabled some of the accused to act with impunity.

While Vice President of Vishva Hindu Parishad, and the General Secretary of Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra, Champat Rai has stepped down for moral reasons, investigators are looking at former trust member Anil Mishra for his role in hiring temple staff. The Special Investigation Team is still looking into the case, and the Enforcement Directorate and Income Tax Department are also following the money and assets. Opposition parties are using the scandal to call for greater transparency, the full release of the SIT report, and changes to how the temple is run.

Delhi roads get a big boost

"The six-lane tunnel connecting Nelson Mandela Marg to Shiv Murti interchange would provide faster connectivity between west and south Delhi as it connects Urban Extension Road (UER)-II and Dwarka Expressway in West Delhi with Vasant Kunj in south Delhi. It will also benefit traffic coming from Gurgaon and IGI airport towards south Delhi," Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said at a press briefing.

Project will provide faster connectivity between West and South Delhi connecting UER 2/ Dwarka Expressway with Vasant Kunj in South Delhi. Further benefiting traffic from Gurugram, Dwarka, IGI Airport, and West Delhi towards South Delhi.

The NHAI is also proposing Elevated Corridor between AIIMS and Mahipalpur. This link will connect tunnel with Barapullah elevated road thereby connecting West Delhi, South Delhi with East Delhi, Ghaziabad and Noida.

The proposed tunnel passes through Rangpuri (Southern Delhi) Ridgeand terminates before the intersection of Nelson Mandela Marg and Mahipalpur Chhatarpur Road.

To mitigate congestion at this intersection an elevated road is also proposed (1.8 Km) along the Nelson Mandela Marg.

Additional flyover from Chhatarpur towards Mahipalpur is also proposed along the existing flyover. For facilitating right turn traffic from towards Chhatarpur, an elevated U Turn is also proposed.

Length of the Main Carriageway is 6.3 Km. Considering proposed flyover and elevated U Turn along Mahipalpur Chhatarpur Road, the total project length is 8.100 km, including 3.140 km of tunnel, 0.980 km of tunnel approach ramp, 0.554 km Approach with RE Wall, 2.556 Elevated Portion and 0.870 km of at-grade road.

It has been estimated that development of

each lane-kilometer of a National Highway generates average 264 person-days/ day of direct employment and average 55 person-days/ day of indirect employment. Therefore, the project will generate close to 7.54 lakh person-days of direct employment and 9.80 lakh person-days of indirect employment. The project will also induce additional employment opportunities due to increase in economic activity in the vicinity of the proposed high-speed corridor.

The NHAI is also planning an elevated corridor between AIIMS and Mahipalpur, which will connect the new tunnel to the Barapullah Elevated Road.

Once completed, the link is expected to provide seamless connectivity between West Delhi, South Delhi, East Delhi, Ghaziabad and Noida, creating a continuous high-speed road network across the National Capital Region.

Govt pushes Delhi Gymkhana eviction

"In pursuance of sub-section (1) of section 4 of the Act, I hereby call upon you to show cause on or before July 7 at 2.30 pm why such an order of eviction should not be made. And in pursuance of clause (b)(ii) of sub-section (2) of section 4, I also call upon you to appear before me in person or through a duly authorized representative capable to answer all material questions connected with the matter along with the evidence which you intend to produce in support of the cause shown, on July 7 at 2.30 pm for personal hearing. In case, you fail to appear on the said date and time, the case will be decided ex-parte," the estate officer said.

Valuable Government land situated in the National Capital cannot be permitted to remain under unauthorised occupation contrary to Government al determination and larger public interest, the notice read.

The move comes over a month after the Government told the Delhi High Court on May 26 that it would not take forceful possession by June 5 of the 27.3-acre premises which is required for "strengthening and securing defence infrastructure".

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, who appeared for the Government, said eviction proceedings would only be initiated in accordance with law and after giving due notice.

A senior official in the ministry on Wednesday said that they have initiated the eviction proceedings in accordance with the law.

The sprawling premises, situated at 2, Safdarjung Road, in the heart of leafy Lutyens' Delhi, were leased to the Imperial Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd (now known as Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd) for maintaining a social and sporting club. It stands adjacent to the prime minister's residence on Lok Kalyan Marg on one of the city's most valuable and strategically important land parcels, within the

high-security administrative zone that also houses several key central Government and defence establishments.

IAS officer arrested on retirement day

No fixed deposits were made. Instead, fraudulent debit transactions occurred, resulting in a loss of about ₹169 crore for the HSPCB. This is described as the largest departmental loss in the case. The funds had a "direct nexus with the fraud" and were transferred as part of an alleged conspiracy involving the accused bank officer. This case is part of a larger alleged banking fraud involving nearly ₹504 crore, though some reports say the amount could be as high as ₹657 crore, from eight Haryana Government departments. Investigators say public funds were diverted using fake or non-existent fixed deposits, unauthorised transactions, and shell companies.

The CBI took over the investigation from the Haryana State Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau at the state Government 's request.

Kumar reportedly avoided investigators for several days, keeping his phone off and his location unknown. A CBI team visited his home earlier but did not find him there. He had applied for anticipatory bail at the Special CBI Court in Panchkula, with a hearing set for July 2.

The CBI eventually found him and arrested him on June 30, his last day at work.

Kumar is the third IAS officer to be arrested in this case. Earlier, Ram Kumar Singh was arrested in connection with funds from the Municipal Corporation, Panchkula, and Pankaj Aggarwal was arrested for links to funds from the Haryana School Shiksha Pariyojana Parishad and the Haryana State Agriculture Marketing Board.

So far, the CBI has filed charge sheets against 17 people, including six officials from IDFC First Bank and AU Small Finance Bank, three Haryana Government employees, two companies, and six private individuals. The agency said related investigations are ongoing in Chandigarh, involving Chandigarh Smart City Limited and other groups. The CBI also reported that a senior IFOs officer has been arrested in one of the Chandigarh-related cases.

The CBI said the investigation is ongoing to track the full trail of the stolen funds, identify everyone involved, and recover the money. Kumar was arrested under sections of the Indian Penal Code and the Prevention of Corruption Act. More proceedings, including remand, are expected soon. The case highlights major problems in how Government funds were managed in private banks and the suspected collusion between some officials and bank staff.

Varanasi security agency denies role in Ayodhya Ram Temple donation scandal

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

A private security agency from Varanasi says it had no part in the alleged embezzlement of donations at Ayodhya's Ram Temple, explaining that it only provided staff to the State Bank of India (SBI) when asked. However, six of the eight people arrested by the Special Investigation Team (SIT) were hired by Sainik Security Services (SSS), putting the agency at the centre of the controversy.

The agency director Gaurav Singh said the company hired 19 to 22 people and sent them to SBI's Naya Ghat branch in Ayodhya for house-keeping work.

He explained, "Temple is not our client. The SBI is. We are the second vendor." He also said, "What work the bank assigned to them thereafter is not known to us." According to Singh, the local SBI branch chose 19 people for the cash-counting team. The agency maintains it only supplied workers and did not decide their duties or supervise them at the temple.

The arrested recruits, Anukalp Mishra, Lavkush Mishra, Manish Kumar Yadav,



Ramashankar Mishra (also known as Tinnu Yadav), Avinash Shukla, and Karunesh Shukla or Pandey, worked in the cash-handling unit for donations. They earned about ₹20,000 per month and were responsible for sorting, counting, and securing offerings from hundi boxes.

The other two people arrested are Subhash Srivastava and Tinnu Yadav (a different person from the alias). The SIT is looking into how this team was put together and whether proper background checks were done.

SBI outsourced the demanding cash-counting work to SSS but kept overall responsibility for the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust. This meant that low-paid contract workers

handled cash as it moved from devotees to official records.

The agency says it only supplied staff and that the bank decided their roles, but this raises questions about who is responsible when sensitive tasks are outsourced. Standard operating procedures were agreed upon by the trust in 2025, and SBI required counters to wear pocketless clothing, undergo regular frisking, be subject to random checks, retain CCTV footage for 180 days, and have a security guard from SIS present during counting.

However, none of these rules was followed. CCTV footage was kept for only 45 days, no guard was present, and basic safety steps were ignored.

SBI officials reportedly noticed problems and suggested changing the counting staff three months earlier, but trust officials are said to have resisted. Two SBI employees who supervised the process are also being investigated. Police have recovered about ₹79.85 lakh in cash from the accused, and some reports say the trust recovered around ₹58 lakh internally before the formal FIR was filed.

SSS presents itself as just a vendor with a limited contract. But by providing the staff who ran the cash-counting unit without strong vetting or supervision, the agency became a key contributor to the failures. The SIT is now looking at how staff were recruited, the local branch's role, and the ignored procedures to see if workforce suppliers are responsible when their employees are entrusted with sacred donations.

As the investigation looks into financial records and possible large-scale theft, Sainik Security Services' claim of a limited role will be closely examined, since most of those arrested at the counting table were its employees.

Government grants one-year extension to Foreign Secretary

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC) has approved a one-year extension in the tenure of Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri, according to an order issued by the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) on Wednesday.

Misri, a 1989-batch Indian Foreign Service (IFS) officer, will continue in service beyond his scheduled retirement date of July 14, 2026.

According to the Government order, the ACC has approved the extension of Misri's service for one year beyond July 14, 2026, allowing him to remain in office until July 14, 2027, or until further orders, whichever is earlier.

"The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet has approved the extension in service of Shri Vikram Misri,

IFS (1989), Foreign Secretary, for a period of one year beyond 14.07.2026, i.e., up to 14.07.2027, or until further orders, whichever is earlier, in terms of the provisions of F.R. 56(d)," the order stated.

The order was issued on July 1, 2026, by the Secretariat of the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet under the Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions, Department of Personnel and Training.

The communication was signed by Manisha Saxena, Secretary, Appointments Committee of the Cabinet and Establishment Officer.

The extension ensures continuity in the leadership of the Ministry of External Affairs, with Misri set to continue as India's top diplomat for another year under the provisions of Fundamental Rule 56(d), which governs extensions in service for eligible Government officials.



UP Govt gives SIT 15-day extension in Ram Temple donation case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Lucknow

The Uttar Pradesh Government has given a 15-day extension to the Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing allegations of embezzlement of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya, officials said on Wednesday.

The tenure of the SIT has been extended to probe the matter in depth and broaden its scope, they said.

gate alleged financial irregularities involving donations to the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Temple. The team submitted a preliminary report on June 23. After an FIR was filed on June 25, police arrested eight people: Avinash Shukla, Anukalp Mishra, Lavkush Mishra, Manish Kumar Yadav, Karunesh Pandey, Ramashankar Mishra, Subhash Srivastava, and Ramashankar Yadav, also known as Tinnu Yadav.

The case centres on claims that donations and offerings from devotees were taken from



the temple's donation boxes, or hundis. Reports suggest the suspected embezzlement could total ₹7 crore, including cash and possibly jewellery. So far, police have recovered about ₹79.85 lakh in cash from the

accused, along with other items previously recovered by temple officials. Vijay Vishwas Pant (IAS, Divisional Commissioner, Lucknow), Kiran S (IPS, Inspector General of Police), and Neel Ratan (Special Secretary,

Finance Department).

The extension, granted on July 1, 2026, pushes the deadline for the final report to July 15. Officials said the additional time will enable a more comprehensive examination of financial records, CCTV footage, donation counting processes, and all related aspects to reach a logical conclusion.

The case has attracted widespread attention. The case has drawn significant attention because the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya is an

important religious site, built through large public donations and devotion. Keeping the donation process transparent is considered essential for maintaining public trust in the temple.

The Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath has emphasised a fair and thorough probe. The accused have been produced before a local court in Ayodhya and remanded to judicial custody. Further questioning and evidence collection are ongoing as the SIT broadens its investigation.

Modi, Japan PM Takaichi to hold annual summit to advance bilateral ties

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi will arrive in New Delhi on Wednesday evening for a three-day official visit to India, marking her first bilateral visit since assuming office. She will hold wide-ranging talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi during the 16th India-Japan Annual Summit on Thursday.

The summit is expected to review the entire spectrum of bilateral cooperation and chart the future course of the India-Japan Special Strategic and Global Partnership.

The two leaders will also exchange views on key regional and global developments, focusing on strengthening economic, strategic and security cooperation in the Indo-Pacific.

The visit comes less than a year after Prime Minister Modi travelled to Tokyo, where Japan committed to more than doubling its investment in India to over \$61 billion over the next decade, underscoring the growing economic partnership between the two countries.

According to official sources, Modi and Takaichi will also participate in business engagements involving



Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi waves upon her arrival at the airport in New Delhi

leading industry representatives from both countries. Around 1,400 Japanese companies currently operate in India, nearly half in the manufacturing sector, reflecting Japan's significant role in India's industrial growth.

India and Japan elevated their ties to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, and cooperation has expanded steadily across trade, investment, defence, economic security, science and technology, infrastructure, culture and people-to-people exchanges.

As the two countries prepare to celebrate the 75th

anniversary of the establishment of diplomatic relations in 2027, both sides are expected to reaffirm their commitment to deepening the partnership.

The India-Japan Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement, which came into force on August 1, 2011, has provided a strong foundation for expanding economic engagement. Bilateral trade crossed \$27 billion during 2025-26, while Japan remains India's fifth-largest investor, with cumulative foreign direct investment of \$48.17 billion between April 2000 and March 2026. Government data also show

Japanese investment worth \$3.2 billion between April and December 2025.

The two leaders are also expected to discuss enhancing defence and maritime cooperation, supply chain resilience, emerging technologies and efforts to promote a free, open and inclusive Indo-Pacific.

India and Japan, along with the United States and Australia, are members of the Quad grouping and have significantly strengthened strategic coordination in recent years. Japan continues to play a key role in India's infrastructure development, including the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail project.

Japanese companies have also expanded their footprint in India's financial sector, with a recent \$1.6 billion investment securing a 20 per cent stake in Yes Bank.

Beyond strategic and economic ties, cultural relations remain a cornerstone of the partnership. Shared Buddhist heritage, growing interest in yoga and expanding educational and people-to-people exchanges continue to reinforce the long-standing friendship between the two nations.

Iran invites BJP, Congress leaders for Khamenei funeral

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Iran has extended invitations to senior leaders from both the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the opposition Congress to attend the state funeral of former Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in Tehran next week.

BJP President Nitin Nabin and Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge along with senior Congress leader and former External Affairs Minister Salman Khurshid have been invited to represent the party at the funeral. Sources said Kharge is yet to decide whether he will travel to Tehran, while the Congress is also considering sending a delegation led by a senior leader.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who reportedly received a personal invitation from Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, is unlikely to attend the ceremony. Official sources indicated that the Prime Minister is expected to skip the funeral due to prior overseas commitments and may instead depute a high-level Indian delegation.

According to sources, the delegation is likely to include Minister of State for External Affairs Pabitra Margherita and Bihar



Iran has extended invitations to senior leaders of India's ruling BJP and the Opposition Congress for the state funeral of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, following his death in US-Israeli strikes on February 28

Governor Lt Gen Syed Ata Hasnain (Retd).

Khamenei, who was killed in a joint US-Israeli strike on the opening day of the conflict in February, will be accorded a state funeral in Tehran beginning July 4.

He is scheduled to be buried in his hometown of Mashhad on July 9.

The funeral, originally planned for March, was postponed because of the continuing conflict in the region.

The Prime Minister's reported decision not to attend has drawn criticism from opposition leaders, who have alleged that New

Nation Focus



Government to upgrade rice quality for public distribution

The Government on Wednesday decided to upgrade the quality of rice distributed to over 80 crore people through ration shops by reducing the percentage of broken rice in the overall supplies. In a post on X, Union Food and Consumer Affairs Minister Pralhad Joshi informed that the Union Cabinet has decided to reduce the limit of broken rice supplied through ration shops.

For raw rice, the limit has been reduced to 10 per cent from 25 per cent. For par-boiled rice, the percentage has been cut to 5 per cent from 16 per cent.

Under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the Cabinet has taken a historic and transformative decision to further strengthen India's food security architecture, Joshi said. "For the first time in nearly three decades, the quality standards for rice distributed under the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana (PMGKAY) have been upgraded," he added.



J&K LG reviews arrangements before Amarnath Yatra flag-off

Jammu and Kashmir Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on Wednesday reviewed arrangements for the annual Amarnath Yatra at the Yatri Niwas in Bhagwati Nagar here, an official said. The 57-day pilgrimage to the 3,880-metre-high Amarnath cave shrine is scheduled to begin on July 3 from the traditional 48-km Nunwan-Pahalgam route in Anantnag district and the shorter but steeper 14-km Baltal route in Ganderbal district.

Sinha was accompanied by Director General of Police Nalin Prabhat, Special Director General of Police (Coordination) SJM Gillani, Divisional Commissioner, Jammu, Ramesh Kumar and other senior officials from civil administration and security forces, he said.

High-level demographic panel briefs Amit Shah, prepares for nationwide assessment

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The High-Level Committee on Demographic Changes met with Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Wednesday to share its operational plan.

The committee will focus on collecting field-verified data about population shifts caused by illegal immigration and other factors.

Led by retired Supreme Court Judge Justice Prakash Prabhakar Navlekar, the group said it will soon start visiting states and Union Territories.

The committee has prepared a detailed questionnaire that will be sent to

state Governments in advance. This will help officials, local bodies, and stakeholders have structured, evidence-based discussions. The panel will also work with relevant Union ministries to check its findings.

The committee was officially formed on May 26, 2026, after Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced the High-Powered Demography Mission on Independence Day 20.

The committee's main job is to study demographic changes caused by illegal immigration and other unusual factors, look at their causes and effects, and suggest policy, legal, and administrative steps. This includes recommending a

strong system for population stabilisation.

Along with Justice Navlekar, the panel includes Census Commissioner Mritunjay Kumar Narayan, former IAS officer Durga Shankar Mishra, former IPS officer Balaji Srivastava, and Dr Shamika Ravi from the Prime Minister's Economic Advisory Council. ncil.

The committee has been told to submit its report within one year, by May 2027, with a possible six-month extension if needed.

At the meeting, Home Minister Shah reviewed the panel's strategy and said he was satisfied with its preparations. He asked Union Home Secretary Govind



Mohan to provide full administrative and logistical support for the visits and data collection.

Shah also emphasised the need for timely recommen-

dations to help guide Government action. This work is especially important as India deals with the long-term effects of uneven demographic changes.

The last full census was in 2011. Without up-to-date national data, it has become crucial to track unusual changes, especially in border districts, cities, and industrial areas, to plan for security, infrastructure, and welfare programs. Security agencies have often pointed out that illegal immigration across open borders is changing local populations in several states.

These changes can put pressure on public services, affect law and order, influence how resources are shared, and, over time, change the social and political makeup of affected areas. The committee's approach aims to go beyond

existing data and gather real-time information through direct contact.

By prioritising visits to states and Union Territories rather than limiting itself to desk research, the panel hopes to gain a detailed view that reflects regional differences. The questionnaire sent in advance should help states gather important data on migration, birth rates, and settlement changes, making field visits more useful.

Officials see the committee's work as a key first step toward policies based on solid evidence. for internal security, sustainable development planning, the equitable allocation of central schemes, and the maintenance of

social cohesion across diverse regions.

With its first major interaction with the Home Minister completed and a fieldwork calendar now in place, the committee is set to move into active data-gathering mode.

Its recommendations, once submitted, are likely to feed into broader Governmental efforts to address demographic imbalances through targeted administrative and legislative interventions.

The meeting on Wednesday has set the stage for a comprehensive, time-bound exercise whose findings could shape India's approach to one of its most sensitive long-term governance challenges.

■ States Focus ■

Punjab launches financial aid scheme for women



HEAVY RAINS PUMMEL MUMBAI METROPOLITAN REGION

Heavy rains battered Thane and Palghar districts and the Mumbai Metropolitan Region (MMR) on Wednesday, triggering widespread flooding in several low-lying areas, leaving citizens stranded in various pockets as stormwater drains overflowed. Authorities have declared a red alert, predicting extremely heavy rainfall in Palghar district in the next 24 hours. The Palghar district administration has declared a holiday for schools and colleges in the district for Thursday, officials said. According to officials, very heavy rains are likely in Thane district in the next three days. The downpour since late Tuesday night caused severe waterlogging across several residential belts. In Ulhasnagar township in Thane district, floodwaters seeped into residential quarters, leaving a 70-year-old woman stranded inside her home in the Jijamata locality for hours before being rescued by fire brigade personnel. Videos of the elderly woman being safely carried through knee-deep water by rescuers have gone viral on social media.



GUJARAT CM LAUNCHES NAMO CLEANLINESS CAMPAIGN

Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel on Wednesday launched the Namo Swachhta and Amrutpan campaigns, aimed at spreading awareness about cleanliness and early child nutrition. He called upon citizens to make cleanliness a shared commitment and a natural habit, according to a release. Under the Namo Swachhta Abhiyan, from July 1 to July 7, hospitals and healthcare institutions across the state will remove obsolete furniture, outdated medical equipment, and unnecessary documents, and thoroughly clean their premises, Patel said. The Amrutpan Abhiyan is a grassroots community healthcare initiative focused on early child nutrition, maternal health, and lactation support.

First Annapurna Yojana funds credited to 1.1 crore women: CM Suvendu

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

The BJP's flagship social security scheme, Annapurna Yojana, which outsmarted former Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee's patent Laxmir Bhandar, sucking a majority of women's votes into the saffron wallet and catapulting her successor Suvendu Adhikari to power, has reached 1.1 crore beneficiaries well within 60 days of the BJP coming to power.

Chief Minister Adhikari announced this at a grand programme at Netaji Indoor Stadium, saying his Government had worked hard not only to fulfil the party's electoral promise but also to silence the sceptics about the practicability of such a humongous scheme requiring funds and an effective filter to sieve out ineligible claimants.

The first tranche of Annapurna Yojana, which ensures a ₹3,000 monthly benefit to the deserving women, had been transferred, the Chief Minister said, adding about 26 lakh applications had been turned down on account of suspect



West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari launches the 'Annapurna Yojana' distribution programme, in Kolkata, West Bengal

citizenship or domicile status, he said. There had been 1.6 crore applications, the Chief Minister said, adding, "Twenty-six lakh of such applications under the Annapurna Yojana have been rejected because scrutiny is required."

The earlier TMC Government had implemented the Laxmir Bhandar scheme, initially transferring ₹1,000 to women and later increasing it to ₹1,500 before the April-May State elections.

The scheme covered more than 2 crore beneficiaries, a large number of whom com-

prised either foreign nationals or male recipients. Only the eligible Indian citizens will receive the fund through the direct benefit transfer scheme (DBT), and no non-Indian will get it, the Chief Minister said, adding, "We cannot transfer taxpayers' money from the government coffers to non-Indians."

Already hundreds of males, mostly close to the Trinamool Congress, who were receiving Laxmir Bhandar — a scheme targeting women only — have been identified and de-notified by the present Government.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Dhuri

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Wednesday rolled out his government's monthly financial assistance scheme for women — 'Mawan Dhiyan Satkar Yojna', stating that AAP fulfilled its final poll "guarantee" made ahead of the 2022 Assembly elections.

Under the scheme, women from the general category will receive ₹1,000 per month, while those belonging to the Scheduled Castes will receive ₹1,500. Addressing a gathering of women, Mann described the day as "historic" and said the state government rolled out this "landmark" initiative under which more than 40 lakh women have already been registered.

"The 'Satkar Raashi' has started from July and it will pave the way for women empowerment. This is an ambitious scheme and we have launched it with complete planning to ensure that it continues permanently," he said. Some women at the gathering said they received messages about money



Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann submits the Enumeration Form under the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral rolls at Dhuri in Sangrur district

being credited to their bank accounts.

Mann said beneficiaries above the age of 18 would receive messages regarding the financial assistance.

"The funds will be directly transferred to bank accounts and women who are already receiving social security pensions will also be eligible under the scheme. Around 97 per cent of women in Punjab are expected to benefit and the state government has earmarked ₹9,300 crore in the budget for this purpose," he said.

Taking on the rival parties, Mann slammed the opposition for "always targeting" his government over this scheme and said now their mouths will be shut following the implementation of 'Mawan Dhiyan Satkar Yojna'.

Mann said although the financial assistance may not make women rich, it would certainly provide them with dignity and self-respect.

"Women deserve the highest respect because they are the source of life itself. The blessings of our mothers and sisters can help us over-

come every challenge in the world. Strengthening women's financial autonomy is essential for improving household welfare, promoting gender equity and enhancing women's participation in social and economic decision-making," he said.

He assured beneficiaries that the scheme will never stop because it is an act of trust reposed in the people.

"Mobile phones of women will start beeping with notifications, ushering in a new era of prosperity where women live with dignity and pride," he stated.

Tax collected from the people belongs to them and the government is spending it judiciously for their welfare, he said.

"People's money is coming back to the people through development, schools, hospitals and roads. The state government is working only for the people," he said.

The first instalment of ₹4,500 for the Scheduled Castes and ₹3,000 for the general category women was transferred to the bank accounts of beneficiaries on Wednesday.

AAP DELAYED WOMEN'S AID IN PUNJAB FOR YEARS, NOW ACTING AHEAD OF POLLS: BJP

Chandigarh: Punjab BJP president Kewal Singh Dhillon on Wednesday accused the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government of rolling out the financial assistance scheme for women now for political mileage, even though it was a poll promise made years ago. Dhillon alleged that the government had not released any money to eligible women for over four-and-a-half years and was now announcing payments with an eye on the elections due next year.

He claimed eligible women should have received between Rs 60,000 and Rs 90,000 over the five-year term, but the government was releasing only a limited amount.

The BJP leader alleged that the government had earlier said it would release payments for April, May and June, but had instead announced payments for July, August and September.

He also accused the AAP government of ignoring key



Kewal Singh Dhillon

public issues, alleging that farmers were facing power shortages during the paddy transplantation season and government employees were protesting over pending demands, including dearness allowance (DA).

Dhillon further criticised the government over the proposed sacrilege prevention law and a recent controversial video involving Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann, accusing it of trying to divert attention from its failures.

He said the people of Punjab would give a befitting response to the AAP government in the 2027 Assembly elections.

India, Pakistan exchange lists of prisoners, fishermen under Consular Pact

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

India and Pakistan on Wednesday exchanged the lists of civil prisoners and fishermen lodged in each other's custody through diplomatic channels simultaneously in New Delhi and Islamabad, in accordance with the bilateral Agreement on Consular Access signed in 2008.

Under the agreement, both countries exchange these lists twice every year—on January 1 and July 1—as part of confidence-building measures aimed at facilitating consular access and expediting the release and

repatriation of detainees.

According to the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), India shared the names of 386 civil prisoners and 53 fishermen in its custody who are Pakistani nationals or are believed to be Pakistani. Pakistan, in turn, provided lists of 52 civil prisoners and 198 fishermen in its custody who are Indian nationals or are believed to be Indian.

The Government of India reiterated its call for the early release and repatriation of all Indian civil prisoners and fishermen, along with their boats, as well as missing Indian defence personnel believed to be in Pakistan's custody.



New Delhi urged Islamabad to expedite the release of 188 Indian fishermen and civil prisoners who

have completed their sentences. It also sought immediate consular access for 13 civil prisoners believed to be

Indian nationals who have not yet been granted such access by Pakistan. India further called upon

Pakistan to ensure the safety, security and welfare of all Indian and believed-to-be-Indian prisoners until their release and repatriation.

The MEA highlighted that sustained diplomatic efforts have led to the repatriation of 2,661 Indian fishermen and 78 Indian civil prisoners from Pakistan since 2014. Of these, 500 fishermen and 20 civil prisoners have been repatriated since 2023.

The biannual exchange of prisoners' lists remains one of the few structured mechanisms of engagement that continues between the two neighbouring countries despite strained bilateral relations.

Karnataka drought action plan prepared: Dy CM Parameshwara

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Belagavi (Karnataka)

Karnataka Deputy Chief Minister G Parameshwara on Wednesday said the state government has prepared an action plan to tackle a possible drought due to deficient rainfall and earmarked ₹5 crore for each district to ensure an adequate supply of drinking water.

Warning that the situation could become "precarious" if rainfall remains deficient in July, he said almost all reservoirs in the state

have reached dead storage due to poor rainfall. "We hope there will be good rainfall sometime in July," he added.

Parameshwara, who also holds the Revenue portfolio, chaired a review meeting with deputy commissioners, zilla panchayat chief executive officers and assistant commissioners of the seven districts in the Belagavi division.

"An action plan has already been prepared at the state level and will be implemented by the deputy commissioners. An alloca-



G Parameshwara

tion of Rs 5 crore has been earmarked for each district to ensure drinking water supply," he said.

Speaking to reporters after

the meeting, he said a separate action plan would be prepared for other works and projects, if required.

Noting that the government had reviewed issues affecting the Belagavi region, particularly those arising from below-normal rainfall this year, the deputy CM said necessary steps would be taken to address drinking water shortages and crop losses.

He said drought-like conditions were emerging in Belagavi district, increasing the likelihood of a drinking

water crisis.

Rainfall during June in the seven districts of the Belagavi division was below normal, resulting in a decline in reservoir and groundwater levels, he added.

"If sufficient rainfall does not occur in the coming days, the situation could become one we have never faced before. The government has discussed precautionary measures, prepared an action plan and issued directions to ensure an adequate supply of drinking water," he said.

Women Farmers Empowerment Bill introduced in Maharashtra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

The State Government on Wednesday introduced the Maharashtra Women Farmers Empowerment Bill, 2026, to provide recognition to the women involved in farming and allied activities irrespective of whether they own land so that they get access to various welfare schemes.

Introduced by agriculture minister Dattatray Bharne

in the legislative assembly, it provides for the creation of a database of women farmers and a state fund for them, among other things.

The bill seeks to accord legal recognition to women engaged in agriculture and allied activities as farmers, irrespective of land ownership, enabling them to access government welfare schemes, institutional credit, subsidies and agricultural extension services.

It aims to address the



long-standing exclusion of women working in agriculture, particularly landless cultivators and those engaged in sectors such as dairy, fisheries, poultry, animal husbandry, sericulture, apiculture and collection of minor forest produce.

"The systemic non-recognition of women farmers and their agricultural labour is significant and leads to other forms of exclusion and discrimination," Bharne said.

Govt disbursed over ₹68,000 cr as welfare pensions: CM Naidu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Punnapuvaripalem

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Wednesday said his government has disbursed more than ₹68,000 crore as welfare pensions since assuming office.

Addressing a public meeting at Punnapuvaripalem village in Nellore district, the Chief Minister said the TDP-led government is disbursing ₹2,712 crore to 62.2 lakh people every month as pensions.

"The people's government has disbursed ₹68,598 crore as pensions until now. Every month, ₹2,712 crore is being disbursed to 62.2 lakh people as pensions," said the CM.

Highlighting the Government's performance



over the past two years, Naidu said his administration has rebuilt the state and restored the systems that were allegedly weakened by previous Government.

Noting that the state government has been able to deliver welfare and development schemes with the help of the Centre, he expressed

confidence that Nellore district will emerge as India's top district in terms of development and wealth creation.

He said BPCL is setting up a refinery with ₹1 lakh crore near Ramayyapattanam, among other investments.

Naidu added that Nellore would become a logistics hub through the expansion of state highways, national

highways, railway infrastructure and port connectivity.

Stressing the government's focus on irrigation, the CM said a calendar has been released to complete 36 projects.

Until now, ₹24,000 crore has been spent on irrigation projects, said Naidu, promising to complete Veligonda project crucial to Nellore district for providing it with water, among other projects.

Referring to the El Nino effect, he said rainfall has subsided, impacting rivers. But, the CM said reservoirs currently hold 65 per cent of their capacity due to last year's rainfall in Krishna and Godavari rivers.

Naidu said the government is contemplating interlinking rivers, underscoring that linking Godavari and

Kaveri rivers will help provide water to downstream states.

On rising fuel prices amid the West Asia conflict, Naidu advocated the use of ethanol as alternative to fuel and called on farmers to cultivate crops such as corn, which can support ethanol production.

Naidu announced that the foundation for Rayalaseema steel plant will be laid in Kadapa tomorrow and that steel production will start by 2028.

Claiming that the previous YSRCP government had driven industries out of the state, Naidu said the government prevented Hero Motors from moving to Karnataka and is working towards manufacturing motorcycles in Andhra Pradesh.

Digital governance made administration more effective, transparent: CM Bhajanlal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Jaipur

Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajanlal Sharma on Wednesday said digital governance has made administration more effective, transparent, accountable and citizen-centric, asserting that technology should serve as a tool for social inclusion and public welfare.

Addressing the inaugural session of the 29th National e-Governance Conference at the Rajasthan International Centre, Sharma said the benefits of digital governance must reach the last individual in society and no citizen should remain deprived of development. Highlighting the Centre's



initiatives, he said Prime Minister Narendra Modi has ensured direct transfer of benefits to beneficiaries through Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT), eliminating the role of middlemen with the help of Jan Dhan, Aadhaar and mobile connectivity.

"The aim is to make governance simple, effective and affordable. Platforms like UPI have revolutionised digital transactions, while technologies such as artificial intelligence, data analytics and cyber security are strengthening governance systems," Sharma said.

President urges students to empower underprivileged

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Anantapur (Andhra Pradesh)

President Droupadi Murmu on Wednesday said students should use their learning to empower the underprivileged. Addressing the first convocation of the Central University of Andhra Pradesh in Anantapur, Murmu said students had a responsibility to give back to society. “You have the responsibility to give back to society. Let your learning become a source of strength for the underprivileged,” Murmu said. According to the president, a convocation marks a defining moment and the culmination of years of perseverance and hard work. “They entered the university with dreams, and today they leave with knowledge, confidence and a degree that opens new doors of opportunity for them,” she said. She expressed confidence that the Central University of Andhra Pradesh would



President Droupadi Murmu during the first convocation ceremony of Central University of Andhra Pradesh at Ananthapuramu

emerge as a centre of excellence and contribute significantly to the realisation of the vision of Viksit Bharat by 2047. She also said she was happy to note that the university had developed a long-term vision to become a future-ready institution. Murmu observed that its commitment to the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), especially on quality education, reflected

a sense of responsibility towards inclusive and equitable development. Though the success of the students was the result of their own hard work, she noted that it had also been shaped by the sacrifices of their parents, the guidance of their teachers and the support of society. “Whether they become entrepreneurs generating employment, scientists driving innovation, public

servants working for the people, or philanthropists serving society,” Murmu said. The president underlined that technological advancements were transforming every sector and, in such a rapidly changing world, learning could not and should not end with acquiring a degree. The inclination to continuously adapt to emerging technologies would be one of the greatest strengths for students, she said, advising them to cultivate the courage to explore new ideas and acquire new knowledge. “Our learning-oriented, resilient and innovative youth are our precious national assets,” she said. By combining their knowledge with creativity, determination and a sense of responsibility, the youth could transform challenges into opportunities and contribute to building a more inclusive and prosperous India, she added.

Ruling TVK alleges horse-trading bid by main Opposition, DMK

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

TVK leader and Tamil Nadu minister R Nirmal Kumar on Wednesday alleged horse trading attempt by DMK leadership to lure his party legislators and said that three persons have been arrested by police in this connection.

Based on the complaint lodged by a TVK MLA, the three men, which includes a person identified as Naresh, who is in “close touch” with “DMK leader V Senthilbalaji and his brother Ashok,” has been arrested in connection with “horse-trading,” he said.

Kumar, Minister for Energy Resources, told reporters that for the past about 40 days, his party has been stating that MK Stalin and Edappadi K Palaniswami, top leaders of the DMK and AIADMK respectively, have been trying to form the government through “short-cut.” The minister claimed that



R Nirmal Kumar

on the behalf of DMK leaders such as Stalin and leader of opposition Udhayanidhi, people like Senthilbalaji have contacted several TVK MLAs and offered inducement ranging between Rs 10 and Rs 50 crore.

Meanwhile, the City Police said that a person claiming himself to be the head of a political survey organization was among the three arrested for contacting N Ilayaraja, TVK MLA from Uthangarai Assembly Constituency in Krishnagiri

district. The MLA was lured with Rs 35 crore seeking his “cooperation” over an Assembly resolution against the Speaker.

“Surprised by the proposal, the MLA firmly declined, stating that he had no interest and instructed (accused) Thirunavukkarasu not to contact him again. Thirunavukkarasu allegedly threatened that if the conversation was disclosed, both the MLA and his family would face serious consequences,” a police release said.

Kerala CM orders expert audit of mineral sand mining, probe into PSU irregularities

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala Chief Minister V D Satheesan on Wednesday said the State Government would order an expert audit of mineral sand mining and probe alleged irregularities by Central and state public sector undertakings. Replying to a submission by legislator G Sudhakaran in the Assembly, Satheesan said an expert committee would assess where mineral sand may be extracted and whether such activities could trigger environmental issues in vulnerable regions, including Upper Kuttanad. He said the government would also examine complaints regarding sand removed from the Thottappally spillway estuary and take appropriate action if any irregularities were found.



The CM said a 2009 Water Resources Department order had authorised the removal of sand accumulated at the Thottappally estuary through Kerala Minerals and Metals Ltd, Chavara, to ensure the smooth flow of water before the monsoon. He said a meeting convened by the Alappuzha district collector on June 1 this year decided that the non-mineral sand remaining after the separation of mineral

sand would be used to fill go-tubes for sea wall construction at Chellanam. Satheesan said the state receives royalty in advance on mineral sand extracted from the estuary, which is processed to separate valuable minerals before being sold. He said KMML has paid more than ₹8.70 crore as royalty, while the Central public sector undertaking Indian Rare Earths Ltd has paid ₹4.71 crore.

Assam Rifles conducts biometric registration drive for displaced Myanmar nationals in Kamjong

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Steering a critical initiative for border governance, Assam Rifles, in close coordination with the Civil Administration, Police and Medical Department of Kamjong District, launched a joint identification, verification and biometric registration drive for displaced Myanmar nationals on June 30.

The extensive documentation exercise was carried out across Phaikoh, Shangkhaklok and Aloyo villages in Kamjong District, where displaced Myanmar nationals fleeing ongoing regional instability have been taking temporary shelter. Operating under the explicit directives of the district administration, a joint team consisting of forty civil officials and security personnel meticulously verified identities,



enrolled biometric data and documented demographic profiles. This exercise successfully covered approximately 500 individuals across the three target locations, establishing an authenticated, centralised database for administrative planning and security tracking. This verification drive

constitutes Phase II of Operation Anchor, a structured civil-military initiative designed to balance national security imperatives with regulated humanitarian oversight along the sensitive Indo-Myanmar Border (IMB). The current initiative builds directly upon the operational achievements

of Phase I, which focused strictly on securing the physical border through enhanced electronic surveillance, intensified patrolling and targeted fencing to curb illegal cross-border movement and unregulated infiltration. By transitioning into Phase II, the operational focus expands from border denial to inner-corridor accountability, ensuring that individuals permitted temporary refuge are thoroughly monitored.

The creation of this secure, biometric database eliminates anonymity, aids the civil administration in streamlining essential medical and humanitarian relief transparently and provides the Union and State governments with reliable records to make informed policy decisions regarding border governance and internal security.

BJP SLAMS TELANGANA CM FOR MOCKING NITIN NABIN

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Wednesday slammed Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy for mocking its national president Nitin Nabin, asserting that the Congress leader's sycophancy and arrogance will meet its downfall with the defeat of his party in the upcoming polls in the state.

On Tuesday, Reddy dismissed Nabin's call to party cadres to work for the BJP's victory in the 2028 Telangana elections, saying it took 15 years for the saffron party to win the Assembly polls in West Bengal, and it would meet the same fate in Telangana.

“Recently, a guy came here, Nabin or whatever, I don't really know his name. But he comes here and says the next government is theirs,” the chief minister said at an event in Hyderabad.

“You said the same thing about West Bengal. It took you 15 years (to form a government) in Bengal. Your tricks might have worked there because Mamata Banerjee was at the helm. But here, all our guys are ready, and they will crush you, Reddy said.

BJP national spokesperson Sambit Patra termed Reddy's remarks “objectionable and condemnable”, and said they also reflect the Telangana chief minister's “arrogance” and the “culture of the Congress”.

Reddy's remarks also show how the Congress and leaders are committed to the “servitude of a single family”, Patra charged, in a veiled reference to the Gandhi family.

“Revanth Reddy, you are the chief minister of a state in India. You are a member of Congress, a well-known party. Do you know who the president of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), India's largest political party, is? If you do not know the president of the BJP, India's largest political party, then I feel you are not a competent political worker,” the BJP MP told reporters here.



GP Singh, IPS, DG CRPF, launched the CRPF's 88th Raising Day Public Engagement Campaign — “CRPF@88: A Legacy of Service & Loyalty” at the Directorate General in the presence of senior officers.

CPI unveils official posters for Badlaav Zaroori Hai rally



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Communist Party of India (CPI) on Wednesday unveiled the official posters for its “Badlaav Zaroori Hai” Rally at a press conference held in New Delhi. The posters were released by CPI General Secretary D Raja, along with National Secretariat members P Sandosh Kumar, MP, Dr Bhalchandra Kango, Dr Girish Sharma, Annie Raja, K Ramakrishna, and National Executive member and CPI Delhi State Secretary Prof. Dinesh Chandra Varshney. On September 1, the “Badlaav Zaroori Hai” Rally

will take place at Ramleela Maidan in New Delhi. The rally will bring together people from across the country to demand an end to rising prices and unemployment, quality public education and healthcare, a legal guarantee for MSP, protection of workers' rights, implementation of women's reservation, social justice for Dalits and Adivasis, and the restoration of democracy, secularism and constitutional values. The rally will be preceded by nationwide padayatra from 6 to 15 August, mobilising people across the country around these pressing issues.

Anant Ambani donates 25 electric buses to boost Tirumala's free mobility drive

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Tirupati

Reliance Industries Executive Director Anant Ambani has donated 25 electric buses worth ₹27.5 crore to the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD), along with funding for 50 drivers and EV charging infrastructure, giving a major boost to the temple body's green mobility initiative.

The donation, announced during his visit to the hill shrine on Sunday, is the largest single private contribution to TTD's ongoing electrification programme and is expected to strengthen sustainable transport services for millions of pilgrims visiting Tirumala each year. The contribution marks the largest single private donation to TTD's ongoing electrification programme and is expected to significantly strengthen sustainable transport services for the millions of pilgrims who visit the hill shrine every year.

Following the religious ceremonies, Ambani announced the comprehensive EV support package. The donation includes 25



electric buses, each valued at approximately ₹1.1 crore, taking the total value of the fleet to ₹27.5 crore. Beyond the vehicles themselves, Reliance has committed to funding the salaries of 50 bus drivers and establishing EV charging stations within the TTD complex. The integrated support addresses two of the biggest challenges in expanding electric public transport fleets—availability of trained personnel and reliable charging infrastructure—ensuring the

buses can be deployed and operated efficiently. The latest contribution significantly advances TTD's long-term vision of creating an environmentally sustainable transport ecosystem in Tirumala, where electric buses are increasingly being adopted to reduce emissions and improve air quality in the ecologically sensitive hill town. In addition to the mobility initiative, Ambani also pledged support for the modernisation of the TTD goshala.

Mahua Moitra accuses BJP for alleged egg attack

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

Amid reports of fresh egg attacks — this time on pro-Mamata Banerjee Trinamool Congress MP Mahua Moitra — the Calcutta High Court has directed the Bengal Government to take measures so that eggs are not thrown at arrested persons and prepare guidelines for transporting the accused persons to court or other places. Hearing a public interest lit-

igation, a Division Bench of acting Chief Justice Tapabrata Chakrabarty earlier on Tuesday had issued necessary directions to the State and asked the government to file an action-taken report on egg attacks. Meanwhile, eggs and mud were allegedly hurled at a TMC MP loyal to former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee when she was allegedly attending a party programme at the Kaliganj area in Krishnagar (Nadia).



Moitra alleged that she had been to the residence of a TMC leader, Alifa Ahmed, when the attack took place. Some people allegedly assembled outside the residence of Ahmed and raised

slogans and hurled eggs and mud while Moitra was engaged in a meeting inside, sources said, adding they carried no flag and supported no party. However, Moitra complained that they had been sent by the BJP leadership. It was a BJP-orchestrated attack, she alleged, saying, “After the change of government in the state, law and order has collapsed. The police administration is a mute spectator. The BJP has now planned to attack me.”

UJJAIN SMART CITY LIMITED
Mela Office, Kothi Road, Ujjain (M.P.) 456001 Ph. 0734- 2525856

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

USCL/438 Tender ID: 2026_UAD_517744_1 date 30/06/2026

Ujjain Smart City Limited Invites online bids from eligible bidders - "Request for Proposal for Appointment of Agency for E-Challan Recovery under Integrated Traffic Management System (ITMS)"

Interested bidders may purchase and submit their proposals online at www.mptenders.gov.in.

Earnest Money Deposit	Rs. 1,00,000 /-
Cost of Tender Document	Rs. 12,500/-
Purchase of Tender Start Date	30/06/2026
Pre-bid Meeting	08/07/2026 15:00 hrs
Last date for submission of Technical and Financial Bid (Online)	22/07/2026 upto 17:00 hrs

Note: In case of any mismatch in key dates, key dates showing on e-portal shall be final. For more details, please refer to e-procurement website: www.mptenders.gov.in. Corrigendum or amendments, if any, shall be uploaded on this website only.

For, Ujjain Smart City Limited

Tenders are hereby invited for the purchase and supply of following items:-		
Sr. No.	Name of Work/Item	Period/Tentative Qty
1.	For Verka Sale Depot, Mohali Hiring of commercial vehicles for supply of Verka Milk Products/ Ambient products from sale Depot- Mohali to various stations in Punjab and other states on trip basis.	01 year rate contract initially & may be extended for another three months on mutual consent
2.	For Verka Bathinda Dairy Dsltc of ETP equipments for upgradation of existing ETP unit.	One complete job
3.	For Verka Hoshiarpur Dairy Sale of unserviceable Machinery and Scrap items lying.	Annual/ one time rate contract
4.	For Verka Sangrur Dairy a) Construction of shed structure including foundations, rebar, priming & painting for CIP system (Area 3325 Sq.Ft.) b) i) Construction of shed structure including foundations, rebar, priming & painting for Curd packing material/incubation room. ii) Laying of floor up to height 3ft. including Brick work, stone aggregate, earth filling and cement concrete.(Area 1500 Sq.Ft.) c) i) Construction of shed structure including foundations, rebar, priming & painting for Powder store/godown. ii) Laying of floor up to height 3ft. including Brick work, stone aggregate, earth filling and cement concrete.(Area 3375 Sq.Ft.)	01 No. 01 No. 01 No. 01 No.
5.	For Verka Ludhiana Dairy Insurance of plant, machinery and building (Whole plant/unit including new expansion projects) against fire, earthquake & FST Risks/STFI Risks (Storm, Tempest, Flood, Inundation, Hurricane, Cyclone, Typhoon, Tornado) etc. for Verka Ludhiana Dairy and its chilling centres i.e. MCC Raikot, MCC Machiwarra Sahib, MCC Bija & MCC Ramgarh Sardaran.	One Job
6.	For Verka Jalandhar Dairy a) Hiring Maintenance engineer and instrument technician for spray dryer milk powder plant capacity 25 MTPD. b) Supply, installation and commissioning of Paneer Pressing Machine and Paneer Cutting Machine. c) Modifications of existing Butter churn Gear box system.	One Job 01 Job One Job
7.	For Verka Amritsar Dairy a) Purchase of Single Phase high capacity Dairy barn Ventilation fan with motor. b) Hiring of Insulated single Portion Road Milk tankers (Capacity- 10000 Ltr.) for the transportation of Milk from BMC/MCC to Verka Amritsar Dairy. c) Hiring of vehicle for supply of Fresh Milk and Milk Products at:- i. Fg.Churrian & surrounding area. ii. Local Route	100 No's Two Year/ 10 No's Annual Annual
8.	For Verka Mega Dairy, Bassi Pathana a) Sodium Alginate b) Xanthan Gum	Annual Annual
NOTE: 1. For complete details regarding above tender (NIT), please visit our website i.e. www.verka.coop & e Tendering portal i.e. eproc.punjab.gov.in . 2. Corrigendum, if any, will be uploaded on website only.		
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Editor's
TAKE

Delhi's voter roll reckoning

As booth-level officers begin a door-to-door count of 1.45 crore voters, Delhi inherits an exercise that has already convulsed Bihar and Bengal

From this week, more than 13,000 booth-level officers are fanning out across Delhi's 70 assembly constituencies to verify the capital's voters. This is Delhi's first Special Intensive Revision (SIR) since 2002: every name must now be matched against that decades-old roll, and those who cannot be linked to it – chiefly newer residents and migrants – must produce prescribed documents or trace their parentage back to 2002. The Election Commission, invoking its constitutional mandate under Article 324 and Section 21 of the Representation of the People Act, frames this as simple record-keeping: no eligible citizen left out, no ineligible name retained, after decades of unchecked urbanisation and migration. That administrative logic carries real political weight.

The SIR was first tested in Bihar last year, where roughly 65 lakh names were struck off ahead of the state election, prompting opposition allegations that the poor, migrants and minorities were being quietly thinned out. After weeks of hearings, the Supreme Court on May 27, 2026 unanimously upheld the exercise as within the Commission's mandate, while ordering safeguards: citizenship-linked deletions must go to a competent authority with notice and hearing, and wrongly dropped voters retain a right to judicial review.

Nearly six crore names had been removed nationwide – including in West Bengal, where the Commission admitted a flawed algorithm had wrongly flagged over a crore names. Locally, the politics cut sharper: the BJP, having recently reclaimed both the Assembly and the municipal corporation from the AAP, has welcomed the drive and accused rivals of inflating rolls; the AAP and Congress echo the disenfranchisement fears raised elsewhere.

For Delhi, the stakes are concrete. This is a city of transience – renters who shift addresses every few years, lakhs of migrant workers in unauthorised colonies, women who relocate after marriage – exactly the voters earlier SIR rounds struggled to capture cleanly.

Officials concede the mapping was already squeezed by an overlapping Census house-listing exercise, leaving a tight runway to the October 7 final roll. Get this wrong, and the consequences will outlast this revision, shaping the 2027 municipal polls and beyond. Avoiding the glitches seen elsewhere – app outages, forms dumped at tea stalls, overworked BLOs, citizens panicked by clerical slips – will take more than good intentions.

The Commission should keep its software biased toward inclusion, publish any flagged names locally and early enough to be corrected, and ensure BLOs actually reach migrant bastis and rental clusters, not just the easiest doors. Political parties' booth agents and independent observers should be allowed to watch the process as it happens, not only audit it afterward.

The Supreme Court has given the Commission legitimacy and a rulebook; Delhi's task is to use both. The real test of this SIR is not how many names it adds or removes, but whether, on October 7, voters trust the list they find themselves on.

A verdict on failure, not a new ideology

Colombia's presidential election marks more than a change of government; it reflects a profound crisis of public confidence. The victory of political outsider Abelardo de la Espriella, following years of unfulfilled promises from both the left and the traditional right, underscores a growing impatience with insecurity, economic stagnation and weak state authority



NILANTHA
ILANGAMUWA

Twelve hours before Colombians cast their ballots in the 21 June presidential run-off, President Gustavo Petro announced that security forces had killed Iván Idrobo, the FARC dissident commander known as “Marlon” – second-in-command to Néstor Vera, alias Iván Mordisco, and one of the most wanted men in the country's southwest. Petro called it the heaviest blow yet against armed criminal structures in western Colombia. The timing was almost too apt: a state still fighting, region by region, to hold ground that has never fully been its own, even as the political project that promised to win that ground through negotiation was about to lose power at the ballot box.

By the next morning, Colombia had chosen its next president: Abelardo de la Espriella, a 47-year-old millionaire lawyer with no prior political experience, who narrowly defeated left-wing senator Iván Cepeda – 49.66% to 48.7%, a margin of roughly 250,000 votes out of more than 26 million cast, making him the most-voted candidate in Colombian history.

Supporters call him “El Tigre.” Donald Trump, who endorsed him, called him a fighter “just like me.” Commentators reached for the comparison Colombians were already making themselves: Javier Milei in Argentina, Nayib Bukele in El Salvador – outsiders who won less by proposing policy than by promising to demolish a political class rather than reform it. It would be a mistake, though, to read the result as evidence that Colombia has adopted a new ideology. What the vote mainly expressed was fatigue with two projects that had each failed on their own terms. Petro's administration, the country's first left-wing government, had promised social transformation and a negotiated peace with Colombia's remaining armed groups; it struggled to turn that promise into functioning state authority.

The traditional right, for its part, spent two decades promising order without dismantling the land inequality, criminal economies and institutional weakness that keep conflict alive in Colombia's periphery. In the space between those disappointments, a candidate who promised to tear the whole system down – rather than repair it – found room to grow. This pattern is not unique to Colombia. Chile, Argentina, Bolivia, Ecuador and Costa Rica have all swung toward right-wing outsiders in recent election cycles, each time punishing incumbents for insecurity and stagnation without solving either. The cast keeps chang-



That gap points to something the Colombian left underestimated: politics is rarely won by explanation alone. Voters living with extortion, stagnant wages and a daily sense that the state had ceded ground to armed groups wanted proof that someone could seize back control, not just a diagnosis of why control had slipped.

Much of that frustration traces back to Petro's signature policy, “Total Peace,” which rested on a genuine insight – that Colombia's violence has always been entangled with poverty, land inequality and the absence of the state, not ideology alone. But several armed groups treated negotiations as room to expand rather than disarm, deepening their grip on drug

trafficking, illegal mining and extortion while talks dragged on. Communities promised peace often experienced the opposite: a state seemingly negotiating while criminal structures grew up around them. This is the trap both of Colombia's political traditions keep falling into.

The left correctly diagnoses the social roots of violence but struggles to assert authority; the right promises authority but avoids the inequality and institutional decay that let armed groups regenerate. What results, from both sides, is the management of crisis rather than its resolution. De la Espriella now inherits that trap, backed by an informal network of like-minded leaders across the region who built power on similar frustration. The danger is that anger, however satisfying as a campaign message, is not itself a governing strategy.

Punishing the guilty plays well as a promise; it does not build the institutions, fiscal credibility or administrative competence that outlast a single term. His mandate, meanwhile, is a narrow one. Congress remains divided, and Petro, even after formally recognising the outcome, continued to allege fraud and foreign interference in the vote count.

De la Espriella takes office on 7 August with more votes behind him than any Colombian president before him – and less unity than that number suggests. Winning, it turns out, was the easy part. Whether he becomes the leader who finally builds a state capable of holding its own ground, or simply the next performer in a theatre that keeps replacing its cast while leaving the script unchanged, is the question Colombia will spend the next four years answering.

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The writer is a columnist
based in Colombo

‘We have not run out of water. We have run out of values’



RAJYOGI
BRAHMA
KUMAR
NIKUNJ JI

2ND OPINION

We have built dams, passed laws, launched river-cleaning missions and still our rivers die, our lakes shrink and our groundwater disappears. Perhaps we have been solving the wrong problem. Water is not just a resource running out. It is a mirror, and what it reflects about us as human beings is deeply unsettling. We all know the importance of water, air, and sunlight in our lives. Can we ever imagine a world sustaining life without water? The thought itself is so daunting. Of all the 5 elements of nature, water is the most primary which impacts human life at many levels and it's provided to us in abundance by mother nature.

It is synonymous with life for when scientists search for traces of life in other planets, they first look for signs of water. The earth can sustain so many life-forms because 70 per cent of earth's surface is covered with water which is con-

sumed directly or indirectly through the food chain and various life-supporting activities. One of its most vital sustainable aspects is in the form of a water cycle which transforms salty sea water into clean water through rains & snowfall, which is otherwise very scarce on earth.

Unlike fire which devastates everything that comes in its contact, water gets polluted when it comes in contact with soluble impurities. This is precisely what makes water the most accurate metaphor for the human soul.

Like water, human souls are also highly impressionable and degradable, capable of becoming a deity or a demon depending on the environment they inhabit. In the Golden Age, when human souls were utterly chaste & downright innocent, their thoughts, words and mannerism were within the bounds of the highest codes of conduct, as a result all the elements functioned with inborn harmony & in innate regulation.

Rivers never crossed their banks, rains never flooded lands, and the sun, air and earth gave plentiful resources without causing calamity. That harmony was not accidental, it was a direct reflection of the human consciousness that presided over nature. However, with increasing human greed and ego, there has been rampant destruction of natural order. Rising mental degeneration has led to environmental erosion on a massive scale.

Deforestation, toxic industrial discharge, reckless consumerism and unchecked population growth have created a devastating imbalance. But these are symptoms. The disease is internal which is in the form of gradual erosion

of values, conscience and our sense of responsibility towards something larger than ourselves.

Do we ever thank mother earth? How many of us have thanked her for the free- air, water, food, sun and many more things that she has given us since the time we have existed. How many of us have told her sorry for inflicting so much pain to her? Well! The simplest and easiest way to do this is by praying or meditating with positive thoughts which most of us can do. We must realise that natural disasters in particular are a wakeup call as to where we are investing all our energies. Today the situation is grave. In many parts of India, people do not have access to clean drinking water which is the most basic necessity for sustaining life. Riots erupt over water scarcity. State governments fight bitter legal battles over river-sharing.

The day is not far when nations will go to war over water and when that happens, no dam, no policy and no international treaty will matter if the human being controlling the tap has not changed within. It is high time we learn from these warning signals and change , not just our infrastructure, but our attitudes. Water is endowed with great healing, cleansing and life-giving value. It can only fulfil that potential if we keep it and ourselves clean. Remember! a polluted mind will always find a way to pollute its surroundings. Conversely, a conscious, values-driven human being will naturally protect what sustains life.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a columnist

PIC TALK

People gather near a decorated chariot during the annual Therottam (car festival) of the Sri Parthasarathy Swamy Temple, at Triplicane, in Chennai PHOTO: PTI

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TEMPLE THEFT: RESTORE
TRANSPARENCY TO RESTORE FAITH

The alleged irregularities in the handling of donations meant for the Ram Temple in Ayodhya have deeply shaken the faith of millions of devotees.

For countless Hindus across India and abroad, contributing to the temple was never merely a financial act; it was a sacred expression of devotion and an emotional investment in a centuries-old aspiration.

The temple represents not just a place of worship but also the culmination of decades of sacrifice, legal battles and public support.

If the reports of financial misconduct are true, they amount to a profound betrayal of the trust reposed by devotees. Those entrusted with managing these offerings carry a moral responsibility that extends far beyond

administrative duties.

Any misuse of donations at such a revered institution undermines public confidence and tarnishes the sanctity of the temple itself.

The only way to restore credibility is through complete transparency. Every donation, expenditure and financial transaction should be subjected to independent scrutiny and placed in the public domain. Accountability cannot be selective when public faith is involved.

Devotees deserve the assurance that every rupee donated in the name of Lord Ram is used solely for its intended purpose. Trust, once broken, can only be rebuilt through honesty, openness and uncompromising integrity.

YASHASWI BAIRAGI | UJJAIN

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Every martyr deserves equal recognition

The delay in officially acknowledging the sacrifice of six soldiers during Operation Sindoor has raised serious concerns. While governments may withhold operational details for strategic reasons, there can be no justification for delaying recognition of those who laid down their lives in the service of the nation.

A grateful nation must never allow its martyrs to fade into anonymity. Behind every soldier's sacrifice stands a grieving family that bears an irreparable loss with dignity and pride. No parent, spouse or child can ever forget a loved one who made the ultimate sacrifice. These families, along with the soldiers' regiments and fellow servicemen, deserve the nation's enduring respect and gratitude. It would therefore be a fitting tribute if the names of these six brave soldiers were also inscribed at the Baisaran Martyrs Memorial in Pahalgam alongside the 26 civilians who lost their lives in the tragic terrorist attack.

Such a gesture would honour all those who paid the highest price in the same tragic chain of events and reinforce the nation's commitment to remembering every sacrifice equally. National gratitude should never distinguish between civilian victims and soldiers who gave their lives protecting the country.

BRIJ B GOYAL | LUDHIANA

Electoral integrity requires public confidence

The decision of 23 Opposition parties, along with an Independent MP, to jointly approach the Chief Justice of India over the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls reflects growing concerns about the transparency and fairness of the electoral process. Irrespective of political affiliations, preserving public confidence in elections is fundamental to any democracy.

The SIR exercise, now implemented across several states after beginning in Bihar, has reportedly resulted in the deletion of millions of names from electoral rolls. Allegations that many eligible citizens were unable to vote while appeals remained pending have naturally raised questions about due process and voter rights.

Equally concerning is the absence of clear official data regarding the identification of alleged illegal immigrants, despite this being cited as one of the objectives of the exercise.

It is essential that the Commission clearly explains the criteria for deletions, ensures timely disposal of appeals and protects the voting rights of genuine citizens. Free and fair elections require not only impartial institutions but also the confidence of all stakeholders. Greater openness and procedural fairness will strengthen, rather than weaken, India's democratic foundations.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Climate action must move beyond plans

Apropos “India must get ready for climate extremes” (June 30), the alarming rise in temperatures and increasingly erratic monsoons leave little doubt that climate change is no longer a distant threat but a present-day reality.

Although several states have adopted Heat Action Plans, many remain poorly funded and weakly implemented. Vulnerable communities, particularly those living in densely populated urban settlements, continue to face severe shortages of drinking water, shade and healthcare during extreme heat. Similarly, inadequate drainage systems turn heavy rainfall into recurring urban disasters, while rain-dependent agriculture suffers repeated setbacks from unpredictable weather patterns.

India now needs decisive implementation rather than additional policy documents. Heatwaves should be formally recognised as disasters to facilitate quicker relief and dedicated funding. Investments must prioritise urban drainage, wetland conservation, green cover, cooling shelters, early warning systems and climate-resilient agriculture. As climate extremes become more frequent, delaying action will only multiply future losses. Preparedness, resilience and sustained investment are the need of the hour.

K CHIDANAND KUMAR | BENGALURU

Why India’s doctors need health systems as resilient as they are

National Doctors’ Day should be more than a single day of gratitude. It is a reminder that India’s doctors are consistently the first to step forward in a crisis, often at real personal cost – and that gratitude alone will not protect the next generation of patients.



SATENDRA SINGH | TANUSHREE

Every 1 July, India observes National Doctors’ Day, a tribute first instituted in memory of Dr Bidhan Chandra Roy - physician, statesman, and one of independent India’s most respected public figures. But the profession being honoured today looks very different from the one Dr Roy practised. Doctors are no longer confined to clinics and operating theatres; increasingly, they are the first people called upon when a cyclone flattens a coastline, a heatwave fills emergency wards, or an unfamiliar pathogen threatens to overwhelm an entire health system. As such emergencies multiply - driven by climate change, rapid urbanisation and a more interconnected world - individual skill and courage are no longer enough on their own. What India needs urgently is a health system robust enough to match the doctors who staff it.

When disaster and disease become the same emergency

The old boundary between “natural disaster” and “public health crisis” has all but disappeared. A cyclone does not just flatten homes - it contaminates water and triggers disease outbreaks in its wake. A heatwave does not just make people uncomfortable - within days it can fill wards with heatstroke and organ failure. An earthquake generates trauma cases that need intensive care long after the tremors stop; flooding brings diarrhoeal disease, leptospirosis, dengue and malaria; drought brings malnutrition and mental distress. Add rapid urbanisation, an ageing population, industrial growth, air pollution and closer human contact with wildlife, and it becomes clear that health systems can no longer plan for one emergency at a time - they must be built to absorb several at once.

More Than Rescue and Relief

Disaster management is often pictured as rescue teams and relief camps, but healthcare is arguably its most important pillar, and its work spans a far longer timeline than most people realise. Long before disaster strikes, health authorities should already be running disease surveillance, vaccination drives, risk assessments and hospital preparedness plans, and stockpiling essential medicines - an early warning system is only as useful as the machinery’s ability to act on it. Once disaster hits, hospitals must deliver trauma care, surgery, intensive care, maternal care and psychosocial support, while ensuring clean water, sanitation and nutrition in relief camps to head off a second wave of illness. The work then continues for months or years afterward, through rehabilitation, disability support, prosthetics, chronic disease management and the slow return to normal care.

The Pandemic’s Unfinished Lessons

COVID-19 remains the clearest test of this thinking in living memory. India’s response had real strengths: one of the fastest vaccine rollouts anywhere, a vaccination drive of unprecedented scale, expanding laboratory and telemedicine networks, and community surveillance systems that held the line under extraordinary pressure. Yet the cracks were just as visible - shortages of oxygen, ICU beds, trained staff and equipment, broken supply chains, and enormous strain on a workforce already stretched thin. Doctors, nurses and paramedics worked impossible hours with limited protective gear in the early months, facing an unfamiliar virus and constant psychological pressure; many were infected, and some lost their lives in the course of duty. Their commitment deserves to be remembered as one of the finest chapters in India’s public health story. But it shouldn’t obscure the harder lesson the pandemic taught: preparedness is always cheaper, in lives and in money, than scrambling to respond after the fact.



Climate change is already a hHealth emergency

What was once treated as a purely environmental concern is now recognised as one of this century’s defining health threats. Heatwaves are driving up heatstroke, dehydration, cardiac events and kidney disease, hitting outdoor workers, the elderly, children and low-income communities hardest. Floods contaminate drinking water and create breeding grounds for disease-carrying mosquitoes. Storms damage hospital infrastructure, disrupt medicine supplies and displace entire communities. Polluted air adds to the burden of lung and heart disease, while shifting ecological patterns push vector-borne diseases into regions that have never had to manage them before. Food insecurity and undernutrition, too, are increasingly climate-linked.

Hospitals that cannot afford to become casualties

A hospital is supposed to be the one place a community can rely on in a crisis, yet hospitals themselves too often become victims of disaster - brought down by structural weakness, flooding, fire or power failure. Every hospital needs to function as a genuine lifeline facility: earthquake- and flood-resistant construction, fire safety systems, backup power, on-site oxygen generation, a secure water supply, a functioning emergency operations centre and protected health-data systems. That also means having a proper Mass Casualty Incident plan - covering surge capacity, triage zones, rapid staff mobilisation, blood bank readiness, operation-theatre scheduling and coordination with police and fire services - tested through regular mock drills rather than left untouched until a real emergency arrives.

Triage deserves particular attention: prioritising patients to save the greatest number of lives with limited resources is a skill every doctor, nurse and paramedic should be formally trained in, not an improvised call made amid the chaos.

The Injuries No One Sees, and an Old Wisdom’s New Role

Physical injuries are visible immediately; psychological ones often surface only months or years later. Disasters routinely leave behind grief, anxiety, depression, post-traumatic stress and substance misuse, with children, women, the elderly, people with disabilities and emergency responders themselves at greatest risk. Every disaster response plan needs trained counsellors and psychologists

built in from the outset, and healthcare workers need psychological first aid as a baseline skill, not an afterthought. There is a role here, too, for India’s traditional systems - Ayurveda, Yoga, Siddha, Unani and Naturopathy - not as substitutes for modern trauma care or surgery, but as genuine complements during recovery: nutritional support in chronic illness, and breathing and meditation practices that meaningfully ease the anxiety disasters leave behind, used alongside evidence-based medicine, never instead of it.

Building the next two decades

India has made real progress over the last twenty years: specialised disaster response units, stronger emergency medical services, better disease surveillance, expanding Health and Wellness Centres, and a growing digital health ecosystem that includes AI-assisted outbreak prediction, GIS mapping of vulnerable populations, satellite-linked telemedicine and drones delivering medicine to places roads cannot reach. But preparedness still receives a fraction of the attention and funding that emergency response gets. Disaster medicine, mass casualty management, infection control and climate-related health risks need to become a standard part of medical, nursing, AYUSH and paramedical education, not a specialised add-on. Every district hospital should have a current disaster plan and run regular drills. None of this works in isolation; it needs sustained partnership between government, hospitals, medical colleges, civil society and the private sector.

A tribute worth living up to

National Doctors’ Day should be more than a single day of gratitude. It is a reminder that India’s doctors are consistently the first to step forward in a crisis, often at real personal cost – and that gratitude alone will not protect the next generation of patients. The truest tribute India can pay them is to build the system around them: resilient hospitals, trained staff, working technology, and communities that know how to help themselves in the first, chaotic hours of an emergency.

As climate change accelerates and new health threats keep emerging, that kind of resilience is no longer optional. It is the only way to ensure that when the next crisis comes, India’s doctors are not fighting it with one hand tied behind their back.

Dr Satendra is former Executive Director, National Institute of Disaster Management, Government of India and Tanushree is Faculty, FDDI, Ministry of Commerce and Industry

Three new warships made in India join Indian Navy



ANIL BHAT

tiplication entirely driven by domestic manufacturing. It also reinforces the nation’s growing strength in indigenous warship design and construction under the vision of Aatmanirbhar Bharat (self-reliant India).

Hosting the Prime Minister at the commissioning ceremony were Shri R. N. Ravi, Governor of West Bengal, Shri Suwendu Adhikari, Chief Minister of West Bengal, Admiral Krishna Swaminathan, PVSM, AVSM, VSM, Chief of the Naval Staff and senior officials of Indian Navy and GRSE. The commissioning of three major surface warships on a single day is a first-of-its-kind achievement for any shipyard in India and highlights GRSE’s robust shipbuilding infrastructure, advanced technological capability and efficient project execution. Rather than simply scaling up fleet numbers, the simultaneous induction completes a highly coordinated tactical triad spanning three distinct dimensions of naval warfare. The achievement further strengthens the shipyard’s operational preparedness across strategic surveillance, anti-submarine warfare and maritime defence capabilities. Aligned with the objectives of Maritime India Vision (MIV) 2030 and Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision (MAKV) 2047, GRSE is spearheading India’s green maritime modernisation through focused initiatives in shipbuilding and ship repair, modernisation of yard infrastructure, strategic global partnerships, promotion of sustainable maritime practices, and adoption of emerging technologies. By integrating Artificial Intelligence (AI), digitalization and innovation-led solutions across its operations, GRSE is driving efficiency, sustainability and technological excellence, while contributing to the vision of a resilient, self-reliant and globally competitive maritime sector. INS Dunagiri, the second Advanced Guided Missile Frigate built by GRSE under Project 17A, represents a significant advancement in indigenous warship design. Equipped with BrahMos anti-ship and land-attack cruise missiles along with advanced defence systems, the warship significantly enhances the Indian Navy’s strike and defensive capabilities. INS Sanshodhak, the last of the four Survey Vessels (Large) built by GRSE, will bolster the Indian Navy’s hydrographic and survey capabilities, supporting port and harbour approaches, navigation channels and maritime limits, while also aiding oceanographic data collection and Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief (HADR) operations. INS Agray, one of the eight Anti-Submarine Warfare Shallow Water Crafts (ASW-SWCs) under construction at GRSE, is designed for coastal anti-submarine operations and is equipped with advanced Combat Management Systems, lightweight torpedoes, anti-submarine warfare rockets and a 30 mm Naval Surface Gun with approximately 88% indigenous content.

With the delivery of INS Dunagiri, INS Sanshodhak and INS Agray, GRSE has achieved the milestone of building and delivering 118 warships, including 80 warships for the Indian Navy - the highest by any shipyard in the country. Reinforcing its technological leadership, GRSE is the only PSU shipyard to receive the Defence Minister’s Award for Excellence in the Defence & Aerospace Sector for designing the most silent ship for Anti-Submarine Warfare (ASW) operations for the Indian Navy. From building 05-ton boats to 24,600-ton Fleet Tankers, GRSE has demonstrated unmatched versatility and established itself as a pioneer warship builder of the nation. Since 1960, GRSE remains the only Indian shipyard to have delivered over 100 warships and is also the first Indian shipyard to have built a Fleet Replenishment Tanker. It is additionally the first shipyard in independent India to build a Seaward Defence Boat (SDB), the builder of the first-ever Patrol Vessel for the Indian Coast Guard, the first-ever Indigenous Survey Vessel and the first Indian shipyard to export a warship - CGS Barracuda - to Seychelles. Beyond shipbuilding, GRSE has consistently championed indigenous innovation and engineering excellence, securing 100 Intellectual Property Rights (IPRs) from the Government of India and being recognised as the Best Performing Defence Shipyard of India for four consecutive years.

Prime Minister Modi stated, “ Today, on this very soil, an important event linked to Aatmanirbhar Bharat, Surakshit Bharat, and Viksit Bharat is taking place. Today, INS Agray, INS Dunagiri, and INS Sanshodhak are giving new momentum to that journey. These three vessels are also symbols of three important national commitments. They have been built in India, their designs were developed in India. The talent of Indian industries has gone into their construction. The skill of Indian engineers has gone into them. The hard work of Indian workers has gone into them. And this is the greatest strength of the new India.”

On the occasion, the Naval Chief Admiral Krishna Swaminathan, stated, “GRSE has long been a trusted partner of the Indian Navy in ensuring maritime security. On this occasion, I would like to congratulate the GRSE team. I would also like to congratulate our industry partners and MSMEs who have helped us achieve this success. Last year, in Mumbai, the Prime Minister witnessed the first tri-commissioning in India. After 17 months, the second tri-commissioning in Kolkata shows that India’s warship construction capacity, modernity, self-reliance and self-confidence are all gaining new momentum.” GRSE is currently constructing multiple frontline platforms, including one Project 17A Advanced Frigate, four ASW-SWCs and four Next Generation Offshore Patrol Vessels (NGOPVs). In addition, the shipyard is building 30 other vessels, including 13 export platforms, and is in advanced stages of concluding a prestigious contract for the construction of the Next Generation Corvettes. Through indigenous warship construction, export-ready maritime platforms, innovation drive with over 90% indigenous equipment fitted in frontline warships, GRSE continues to reinforce India’s emergence as a world-class maritime and shipbuilding powerhouse. Indian Navy has commissioned a total of nine major warships and vessels so far in 2026.

Col Anil Bhat, VSM (Retd) is a strategic affairs analyst and former Defence Ministry and Indian Army spokesperson



Oil & gas production: The next step in India’s energy security journey



SUSHMA RAWAT

consumers, India will continue to require reliable supplies of hydrocarbons even as renewable energy assumes a larger role in the country’s energy mix. Strengthening domestic oil and gas production must therefore remain a strategic national priority-not only to reduce import dependence but also to support economic growth, industrial development and long-term energy resilience.

India currently imports nearly 90 per cent of its crude oil requirement, making the country vulnerable to global price volatility, geopolitical uncertainties and supply disruptions. While diversified import sources and strategic petroleum reserves have significantly strengthened India’s ability to withstand external shocks, increasing indigenous oil and gas production remains the most sustainable way to enhance energy security, reduce import dependence, conserve valuable foreign exchange and strengthen long-term economic resilience.

However, increasing domestic production

India’s next energy challenge is no longer only securing supplies from global markets. It is increasing the country’s ability to produce more oil and natural gas at home. As one of the world’s fastest-growing energy

requires recognising the unique nature of the upstream business. Exploration and production are inherently long-gestation activities, requiring substantial capital investment and years of geological assessment, appraisal and field development before production begins. At the same time, many of India’s largest producing fields have been operating for decades and are naturally maturing. Sustained production growth will therefore depend not only on continued exploration but also on redevelopment of existing assets and wider deployment of advanced technologies.

Technology will play a defining role in the next phase of India’s upstream growth. Enhanced Oil Recovery (EOR) and Improved Oil Recovery (IOR) techniques, supported by advanced reservoir management, modern seismic imaging and digital technologies, offer significant opportunities to improve recovery from mature reservoirs. Globally, these technologies have helped extend the productive life of ageing fields while unlocking reserves that were previously considered technically or economically difficult to recover.

In this context, the redevelopment of Mumbai High by ONGC, supported by global technical expertise, is especially significant. The programme is expected to improve recovery from India’s largest offshore producing field through advanced reservoir management and modern recovery techniques. Similar technology-led



interventions across other mature offshore and onshore assets can further strengthen domestic production while improving the efficiency and longevity of existing fields.

While mature fields remain an important source of incremental production, new discoveries will determine India’s long-term production trajectory. Large parts of India’s sedimentary basins continue to hold significant hydrocarbon potential. Continuous acreage bidding under the Open Acreage Licensing Policy (OALP), improved access to geological data through the National Data Repository and a stable policy framework have created fresh opportunities for exploration. Timely monetisation of discoveries, faster project execution and continued technological innovation will be essential to unlocking this potential and translating it into meaningful production.

ly shift towards faster execution, sustained exploration, wider adoption of advanced technologies and higher domestic production.

The benefits of stronger domestic production extend well beyond reducing the import bill. Every additional barrel produced within the country strengthens energy security, conserves valuable foreign exchange, supports industrial growth and reduces vulnerability to external supply disruptions. Increased upstream investment also creates employment, strengthens the domestic oilfield services ecosystem, encourages technology adoption and generates wider economic multiplier effects. As India’s upstream industry builds on the Government’s reform agenda, sustained investment in exploration, redevelopment of mature fields and faster commercialisation of discoveries will be critical to achieving durable production growth.

India’s energy transition is progressing rapidly, with renewable energy playing an increasingly important role in the country’s energy mix.

At the same time, oil and natural gas will continue to remain indispensable for transportation, manufacturing, petrochemicals and several other sectors for many years to come. Strengthening domestic hydrocarbon production is therefore not at odds with India’s clean energy ambitions. Rather, it complements the transition by ensuring that economic growth, industrial competitiveness and energy security advance together.

India has already laid a strong policy foundation for revitalising its upstream sector. The next phase should focus on translating that foundation into measurable production outcomes through continued exploration, wider adoption of advanced technologies, faster monetisation of discoveries and timely redevelopment of mature fields.

The opportunity before India is not simply to reduce import dependence, but to build a more resilient, competitive and technologically advanced upstream industry capable of supporting the country’s long-term economic aspirations. Strengthening domestic oil and gas production is therefore not merely the next step in India’s energy security journey-it is one of the defining priorities for India’s future growth and strategic resilience.

The writer is Former Director (Exploration), ONGC

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Order Order

Helmet exemption to Sikhs on reasonable classification: HC

The exemption granted to Sikh men wearing turbans from wearing helmets while riding two-wheelers is not on the basis of religion but "reasonable classification", the Bombay High Court has said, dismissing a petition challenging the same.

Justices Urmila Joshi-Phalke and Nivedita Mehta of the Nagpur bench on Monday dismissed the petition filed by Kirtesh Chaudhari, a 23-year-old student.

The plea challenged a proviso to section 129 of the Motor Vehicles Act which grants this concession, claiming that it violated the right to equality. The high court said the plea was misconceived, and Article 14 of the Constitution (right to equality) prohibits class legislation and not reasonable classification.

"Article 14 permits reasonable classification, meaning thereby the Government can make distinct class for different groups if there is a valid and logical basis and a public purpose," the HC said.

"Exemption given to the Sikhs is not on the basis of caste or creed or religion," the court said.

Under section 129 of the Motor Vehicles Act, every person riding a two-wheeler has to wear a helmet. A proviso to the section says it shall not apply to a Sikh person wearing a turban.

The petition claimed that equality before the law means no person or class should have a special privilege. The Union Government opposed the plea, claiming that the exemption was a reasonable classification. (PTI)

Man gets 10-year jail for selling spurious liquor



A court here has sentenced a man to 10-year rigorous imprisonment for selling spurious liquor said on Wednesday. Additional District and Sessions Judge Vishnu Chandra Vesh on Tuesday also imposed a fine of Rs 2 lakh on the convict, Sonu, after holding him guilty under Sections 272 (adulteration of food or drink intended for sale), 273 (sale of noxious food or drink), 304 (culpable homicide not amounting to murder) and 328 (causing hurt by means of poison) of the IPC, and Section 60 of the Excise Act. The court directed that half of the fine amount be paid as compensation to the victims' family, Government counsel Arun Sharma told PTI.

According to the prosecution, the case was registered against Sonu at the Borakala police station after he allegedly sold spurious liquor in Sisauli village on August 4, 2019. Two people died and another fell seriously ill after consuming the illicit liquor, Sharma said. (PTI)

HC grants bail to two in MP toxic cough syrup case

Two medical representatives arrested in last year's alleged toxic cough syrup case in Chhindwara, which killed over 20 children, have been granted conditional bail by the Madhya Pradesh High Court, their lawyer said on Wednesday. A single bench of Justice Ajay Kumar Nirankari granted relief to the two accused on Tuesday, he said.

In their petition, Satish Verma and Shailesh Singh Pandya had submitted that they had no connection to the production of the toxic cough syrup, and as medical representatives, they had simply placed orders with the company for supplies and were unaware of any adulteration or defects in the medicine. Besides, they also had no role in the storage, distribution, or destruction of the drug, their petition said. The police have completed the investigation and submitted relevant documents to the court.

"The hearing of the case may take time. Applicants Satish Verma and Shailesh Singh Pandya have been in judicial custody since October 2025 and November 2025, respectively," said Sankalp Kochhar, who represented the duo. However, the Government opposed the bail applications, saying the two were accused of playing a role in the promotion of the controversial cough syrup, the supply chain and the development of a prescription network of doctors. The applicants acted as the key link between the main accused Dr Praveen Soni, and the pharmaceutical company. The investigation has found significant evidence against the applicants, the prosecution said. (PTI)



Compensation under MVA to be based on ITR: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a significant verdict aimed at bringing uniformity to motor accident compensation, the Supreme Court on Wednesday laid down guidelines on how courts should determine the annual income of deceased victims or injured claimants on the basis of Income Tax Returns.

The top court held for salaried individuals, only the Income Tax Return (ITR) of the previous year will be sufficient for showcasing the annual income and for self-employed persons, it held that the average income disclosed in ITRs for up to the previous three years should ordinarily serve as the reference point.

A bench of justices Sanjay Karol and N Kotiwar Singh held that there cannot be a rigid formula for computing annual income under the Motor Vehicles Act, but drew a clear distinction between salaried employees and self-employed persons for the purpose of assessing compensation based on their ITRs.

"In the considered view of this court, there can be no hard and fast formula for computing the annual income of a deceased

person/claimant. ITRs being a statutory document are an important reference point when it comes to assessing one's income, for the purposes of compensation under the Motor Vehicle Act," Justice Karol, who authored the judgement, said.

The verdict agreed to the submissions made by senior lawyer JR Midha that there must be a bifurcation made between salaried individuals and self-employed individuals when it comes to assessment of annual income.

Recognising conflicting approaches adopted by different courts across the country, the bench observed that while some courts relied only on the latest ITR, others averaged income reflected in returns for the preceding years, leading to inconsistent awards.

"In our view, for salaried individuals, only the ITR of the previous year will be sufficient for showcasing the annual income from salary. The reason for considering only the preceding year is that the financial impact of promotions is significant and may be reflected in the ITR for only that year," it said.

However, where a promotion or salary revision had taken place shortly before the accident and was not fully reflected in the latest return, courts could also consider



promotion letters and other corroborative financial records, it said.

For self-employed persons and business owners, the bench held that the average income disclosed in ITRs for up to the previous three years should ordinarily serve as the reference point, keeping in view the fluctuating nature of business income.

"In our view, the average of the income specified in the ITRs of up to the previous three years is to be taken as a reference point for assessment of annual income from their business. There may also be a scenario where only one or two ITRs have been filed.

"Given such scenarios and the fluctuation of income in these pro-

fessions, surrounding circumstances are also to be taken into consideration," it said.

The verdict then referred to scenarios which may lead to fluctuations in income of the deceased or injured self-employed victims and said these would include the nature of the business, growth pattern and impact of death on the business and potential growth of business.

It also referred to negative income and any other relevant factor relating to the business that may affect the income of the accident victims.

"The date when the ITRs are filed would also become a relevant consideration, as there may be scenarios where inflated income is shown

after death/injury. In these circumstances, the surrounding factors of the business would become more relevant. However, if sufficiently supported by financial statements, such ITRs may also be taken into consideration," it said.

The judgment came while deciding an appeal filed by the family of a construction businessman, Rashmirekha Tripathy against Sriram General Insurance Company Ltd. The top court also enhanced the compensation payable to the claimants.

Applying the principles to the present case, the bench found that the deceased, a 39-year-old construction businessman, had disclosed annual incomes of about ₹11.6 lakh and ₹15.06 lakh in the two preceding assessment years.

While the Orissa High Court had averaged the two returns and fixed his annual income at ₹13.33 lakh, the top court held that the nature of the deceased's construction business also deserved consideration and fixed his annual income at ₹14 lakh.

Consequently, the court enhanced the compensation payable to the deceased's family from ₹1.87 crore awarded by the high court to ₹1.97 crore, while maintaining interest at six per cent per annum.

Gujarat municipal poll candidates must disclose spouses' assets too: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday held that candidates contesting Gujarat municipal polls are required to disclose not only their own assets but also those owned by their spouses in election affidavits.

The top court also ruled that an error by a magistrate in invoking the wrong statutory provision at the stage of taking cognisance is a curable defect and does not automatically vitiate criminal proceedings.

A bench of justices Sanjay Karol and NK Singh passed the directives while partly allowing an appeal filed by Chandrikaben Kishor Dafda, a former municipal councillor from Gujarat, who had challenged criminal proceedings initiated against her over alleged non-disclosure of certain immovable properties owned by her husband in her nomination affidavit for the 2015 Gujarat municipal elections.

The court, however, did not quash the criminal case. Instead, it set aside the



magistrate's order taking cognisance under Section 125A of the Representation of the People Act, 1951 (RPA), and remanded the matter to the trial court for taking fresh cognisance under the appropriate legal provisions and proceeding in accordance with law.

Writing the judgement for the bench, Justice Karol said

he had expressed no opinion on the merits of the allegations.

The bench referred to the Gujarat Municipalities (Conduct of Elections) Rules, 1994 as amended in 2005 and said, "the appellant (Dafda), in view of the above, had to have disclosed the properties owned by her spouse too".

Plea to set norms for standup comedy shows

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Referring to a controversial "₹370 biryani" remark during comedian Pranit More's show in Gurugram, a plea was filed in the Supreme Court on Wednesday seeking direction to formulate a comprehensive regulatory framework for stand-up comedy, podcasts, social media platforms and artificial intelligence generated content.

The plea filed by advocate Vishal Tiwari also mentioned some recent "false" information being spread online that several Indian judges and Union ministers participated in a badminton tournament in London earlier this month at taxpayers' money.

The petition said that misleading material attained extraordinary circulation within a short span of time and generated extensive



public commentary, criticism and speculation concerning the functioning, independence and propriety of constitutional institutions, before any official clarification could effectively reach the public domain.

Tiwari in his PIL said that existing legal mechanisms are predominantly reactive and become operational only after false information has already achieved irre-

versible virality.

"By the time fact-checks or official clarifications are issued, millions of users may have consumed, shared and relied upon inaccurate information, causing lasting reputational injury and erosion of public trust," the plea said.

"Regardless of whether the statement originated as humour, satire, improvised interaction or entertainment content, its algorithmic amplification transformed an isolated expression into nationwide digital discourse concerning the dignity of women, consent, privacy, public morality and constitutional responsibility," it said.

The petition has sought constitution of an expert committee for enquiry against misleading, degrading and scandalising material circulated on various social media platforms and digital publications as

allegedly depicting a foreign badminton event attended by the Chief Justice of India and judges of the top court.

It has also sought constitution of an independent judicial commission headed by a retired Judge of the apex court to examine dissemination of false and manipulated digital narratives.

A Gurugram firm had earlier sacked one of its employees, who recently went viral for making the controversial "₹370 biryani" remark during More's show after widespread social media outrage over the incident.

Gurugram-based web developer Himanshu Jangra faced a backlash for his comment, prompting Starvik Design, his employer, to fire him from his job. Vivek Vishwakarma, the founder of the firm, had confirmed in a video posted on X.

Delhi HC gives relief to Raghav Chadha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday directed removal of certain objectionable social media content targeting MP Raghav Chadha.

Chadha, who has exited the Aam Aadmi Party to join the BJP, earlier filed a lawsuit in the high court against the publication of alleged malicious and fabricated social media posts, that, he said, were gravely prejudicial to his reputation and personality rights.

"I said no personality rights is involved. However, I have asked to take down (certain content)," Justice Subramonium Prasad said while pronouncing the interim order in the matter.



"Rest all, the content is not defamatory prima facie," the judge added.

A detailed copy of the order is awaited.

The court had reserved verdict on the aspect of interim relief to take down the alleged offending content on May 21.

Chadha, in his plea, had sought immediate removal and takedown of false, AI-generated and deepfake content circulating widely across social media platforms.

NCLAT upholds ED's PMLA powers over insolvency moratorium

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) has said the moratorium available to companies undergoing insolvency proceedings cannot be used to shield assets alleged to be proceeds of crime, while upholding actions taken by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) against Siddhi Vinayak Logistics Ltd..

The appellate tribunal said if there has been any attachment by the ED, then the adjudicatory mechanism created under the PMLA alone will have jurisdiction to deal with it. A three-member NCLAT bench has



upheld the previous order passed by the Ahmedabad bench of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT), saying "tribunals constituted

under the IBC are not the forums which can entertain any plea against the ED".

"The writing is on the wxasall for

the appellant: whether to attach or not to attach the properties of a corporate debtor is for the Enforcement Directorate to decide, and where there has been any such attachment by the ED, the adjudicatory mechanism created under the PMLA alone will have jurisdiction to deal with any challenge to it," said NCLAT.

The legislative intent behind the scheme of the IBC only aims to deal with the issue of corporate insolvency, either in a CIRP or in a liquidation process, and to pay off the creditors of the corporate debtor through the sale proceeds of the legitimate assets of the corporate debtor either as a going concern or as liquidated assets, and not out of the ill-gotten wealth of the CD.

"Otherwise, and as indicated earlier, IBC would unwittingly become a camouflage, a shield, to save the ill-gotten wealth of the corporate debtor and create a classification within the non-discriminatory character of the PMLA," said the bench comprising Justice N. Seshasayee, Arun Baroka and Indevvar Pandey.

NCLAT's observation came while delivering its judgement over the petition filed by the liquidator of Siddhi Vinayak Logistics, challenging ED's withdrawal of ₹2.29 crore from the corporate debtor's bank account during the subsistence of the insolvency moratorium and seeking release of assets and receivables allegedly restrained under the PMLA.

European Hospitals prepare for next heatwave using recent lessons

JOHN LEICESTER ■ Orsay

Paris-region hospital, emergency medics needed it to plunge patients into cold-water baths to speedily bring down their temperatures so they wouldn't join the growing tally of dead from a record-smashing heatwave. But lacking an ice-making machine, where to get it?

A fast-food restaurant helped out last week, saying the hospital could take its ice. Staff also bought ice from the supermarket. The Paris-Saclay Hospital has now ordered its own ice machine, eagerly awaited in the emergency department for a future attack of sizzling heat. Whether that hits next week, as France's weather service says it might, or in summer months



ahead, medics and hospital administrators are acutely aware that the battle they've just endured will, because of climate change, be followed by others. Just as they brace for the annual flu season, they know that fighting heatwaves is becoming their

new normal. So as they catch their breath from what the director of the public hospital described as a "horrible" last week, he and his staff are also gearing up for the next round. "We thought we were ready. We were not actual-

ly," said the director, Cedric Lussiez. "The hospital was working on a 24 hours a day basis because we had to find new solutions in a very short delay," he said. "We already learned some lessons." Efforts to plug some of the holes exposed by the heatwave that shifted eastward to other parts of Europe after battering France, the United Kingdom and other countries are accelerating on a national level, too. When France was baking through its hottest days on record last week, French Prime Minister Sebastian Lecornu announced a 100-million euro (USD 114-million) spend from this summer on cooling systems for hospitals and other work to keep wards functioning. (AP)

Nepal resumes tea export to India

SHIRISH B PRADHAN ■ Kathmandu

The export of tea from Nepal to India has resumed after a gap of two months following ease of regulations by New Delhi, Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal said on Wednesday. Export of Nepalese tea to India was halted from May 1 after the Indian Tea Board introduced strict regulation on its import. It resumed on Tuesday. Foreign Minister Khanal informed the National Assembly that the export of Nepalese tea to India has now been eased. India reviewed its policy regarding import of tea from Nepal, which made it possible, he said, adding that he too had held discussion with high officials regarding the matter during his recent visit to India. India is the major market for tea produced in Nepal. "Export of Nepalese tea to India resumed from Tuesday, June 30, after India eased the regulation (to import Nepalese tea)," said Kamal Mainali, president of Nepal Tea Association. With the easing of the regulation, trucks carrying Nepalese tea consignments have started heading towards India, Mainali said. Nepal had taken diplomatic initiative to ease regulation to export tea to India. Nepal's tea manufacturers had halted their production for about two months after India introduced strict regulation on the import of Nepalese tea. Now, as against the 100 per cent sampling test, the Indian authorities will take a sample of only 20 per cent tea being exported from Nepal and allow the consignment if it meets the required standard. As per the new arrangement, samples will be taken from only one out of five trucks for testing purposes before issuing export permits, Mainali said. (PTI)

Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal



Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal

Pakistan holds funerals for 14 children after tutoring centre collapses

BABAR DOGAR/KM CHAUDHRY ■ Lahore

Mourners gathered Wednesday in Pakistan's eastern city of Lahore to bury 14 schoolchildren who were killed when the roof of a tutoring centre collapsed on Tuesday. Police are investigating whether negligence during ongoing construction work caused the collapse that left another eight children injured and hospitalized in stable condition. Residents and preliminary police findings indicate the tutoring centre was operating in an aging building. Investigators believe the unfinished roof of the second floor



People carrying the bodies of children, who were killed in a roof collapse at a tutoring center on the outskirts of Lahore, Pakistan for funeral prayer on Wednesday

AP

Tharoor and JGU's Prof C Raj Kumar address Diet on academic ties

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Tokyo

In a rare honour reflecting the growing depth, maturity, and strategic importance of India-Japan relations, Professor C Raj Kumar, founding Vice Chancellor of OP Jindal Global University (JGU) and Dr Shashi Tharoor, Member of Parliament, India, addressed a distinguished bipartisan gathering of Members of the National Diet of Japan at the National Diet Building in Tokyo. According to a Press note, their addresses highlighted the complementary roles of higher education and parliamentary diplomacy in advancing one of Asia's most important democratic partnerships through research, innovation, academic collaboration, and people-to-people engagement. The significance of the interaction was heightened by coinciding with the official visit of the Prime Minister of Japan Sanae Takaichi to India and the India-Japan Annual Summit with Prime Minister Narendra Modi. As both Governments continue to deepen their Special Strategic and Global Partnership at the highest political level, the discussions in Tokyo demonstrated that enduring bilateral relationships are strengthened not only by governments but also by parliaments, universities, scholars, students, industry, and civil society, said the Press note. The interaction was chaired by Fukushima Nukaga, the 80th Speaker of the House of Representatives of Japan, and brought together an exceptional and bipartisan gathering of Members of the National Diet representing both the House of Representatives and the House of Councillors. The meeting was attended by senior parliamentary leaders, former ministers, government representatives, eminent diplomats, distinguished academics, policy experts, and industry leaders from across Japan. The breadth of participation reflected Japan's strong bipartisan commitment to strengthening parliamentary dialogue, educational cooperation, democratic engagement, innovation, and institutional partnerships with India. On the occasion Raj Kumar spoke of the indispensable role of universities in shaping the future of international relations. He observed that institutions



Member of Parliament Dr Shashi Tharoor, Professor C Raj Kumar posing with a bipartisan group of Members of the National Diet of Japan at the National Diet Building in Tokyo

PIONEER PHOTO



Professor C Raj Kumar



Dr Shashi Tharoor

of higher learning today are far more than centres of education. "Asia's evolving geopolitical landscape demonstrates that the strongest international partnerships are patiently built through sustained investments in education, research, technology, human capital, institutional cooperation, and innovation. India and Japan, he said, possess a unique opportunity to deepen their relationship further by investing in universities, scientific collaboration, entrepreneurship, academic mobility, and knowledge partnerships," he said. Highlighting JGU's own engagement with Japan, Professor Raj Kumar noted that the University's partnerships with 27 leading Japanese institutions and the participation of nearly 200 students in study abroad programmes across Japan reflect a sustained institutional commitment to building long-term academic cooperation. In his address Tharoor reflected on the equally important role of parliamentary

diplomacy and observed that diplomacy is not merely about negotiating interests or responding to crises. Reflecting on the centuries-old relationship between India and Japan, Tharoor said the friendship between the two countries has been nurtured through Buddhism, cultural exchange, democratic values, and deep civilisational respect. "This shared history, is not only a source of pride but also a responsibility. The challenge before both nations is not to create a new friendship but to continually renew and strengthen an enduring one through institutions capable of serving future generations. While governments create strategic partnerships, it is ultimately people who sustain them," said Tharoor. Other distinguished participants include Toshiko Abe, former Minister of Education, Culture, Sports, Science and Technology; Kiyoshi Odawara, former State Minister for Foreign Affairs; Hakubun Shimomura, former Minister of Education, Culture, Sports, Science and Technology; Yasuhide Nakayama, Director-General, Global South Strategy Headquarters amongst others. The Organisers were Masakuni Tanimoto - Secretary-General, Japanese Parliamentary Committee for World Federation; Chairperson, International Committee for World Federation and the Members of the Secretariat - Japanese Parliamentary Committee for World Federation, according to the Press note.

Sri Lanka ends state of emergency

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Sri Lanka on Wednesday announced an end to the state of emergency that was put in effect after the devastating Cyclone Ditwah hit the island nation nearly seven months ago. Cyclone Ditwah that hit Sri Lanka in late November 2025 killed over 600 people and caused severe flooding, landslides, and widespread destruction across all 25 districts of the country. The Government maintained that the state of emergency was needed to expedite disaster response and rescue operations. It also allowed for the deployment of troops to help carry out essential services and coordinate relief recovery and reconstruction efforts.



The state of emergency declared following Cyclone Ditwah will not be extended, Government spokesman and minister Nalinda Jayathissa told reporters. Over 600 people died, 1,20,000 houses were damaged or destroyed, leaving many families displaced and dependent on temporary shelters after Cyclone Ditwah. At least 2.2 million of the 21 million population were exposed to the cyclone and 1.2 million were directly affected as the cyclone displaced hundreds of thousands, and caused major damage to homes, agriculture, transportation networks, schools, hospitals, and public utilities. (AP)

Turkiye tightens security ahead NATO summit

SUZAN FRASER ■ Ankara

Turkiye is rolling out sweeping security measures for next month's NATO summit, deploying tens of thousands of police and placing air defenses on high alert, while banning public gatherings and imposing controversial restrictions on freedom of expression and assembly. That's meant to safeguard the summit, but also to display strength and underscore Türkiye's commitment to NATO, even as it is often portrayed as an outlier within it. On July 7-8, leaders from all 32 member states are expected convene in the Turkish Capital, including U.S. President Donald Trump, whose threats to withdraw from NATO and reduce U.S. troop levels have cast



uncertainty over the alliance's future. Türkiye has also unveiled a new VIP airport, converted from a former military airfield, specifically to host NATO leaders. At the Ankara summit, NATO

members are expected to address questions over defense spending and the US's evolving role in the alliance. The main agenda will center on unity after Trump has criticized allies for failing to support the US-led war on Iran and efforts to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. "The important aspect of the meeting is to what extent the rift between the United States and Europe can be healed or narrowed during the summit," said Fatih Ceylan, a former Turkish ambassador to NATO and security analyst at the Ankara Policy Center. "We should not expect miracles, but nonetheless if there is a convergence of ideas emphasising the importance of NATO, that should be seen as a success." (AP)



Indian Naval Ships Udaygiri, Kavaratti and Shakti of the Eastern Fleet undertake a Passage Exercise (PASSEX) with Royal Thai Navy ship HTMS Chao Phraya following their visit to Sattahip, in Thailand

PTI

Ukrainian drone strikes on refineries spark fuel crisis in Russia

DASHA LITVINOVA ■ Moscow

The lines are growing at Russian gas stations -- and so is the frustration and uncertainty as several months of Ukrainian attacks have set oil refineries ablaze and choked supplies for motorists across the vast country. Fuel rationing has been introduced in many regions, with hours-long queues of cars snaking beside roads. Social media videos show drivers agitated at the lines or swearing at empty gas pumps and rising prices. The mayor of the Siberian city of Irkutsk even ordered portable toilets brought in to accommodate those in line. The fuel crisis - unprecedented for a

nation that is one of the world's biggest energy producers - has brought Moscow's full-scale invasion of Ukraine home to ordinary Russians like few other events in the war, now in its fifth year. It drew a rare admission from President Vladimir Putin, who acknowledged that "problems persist for both motorists and businesses," and "there are still queues at petrol stations, and finding the right grade of petrol isn't always easy." Putin insisted the shortages are "not critical" and "temporary." But that appeared to do little to reassure at least one motorist in Moscow, the wealthy capital typically better-insulated from economic shocks than the rest of the country. "I think the situation is not very good," the motorist waiting in line told The Associated Press on Monday, the day after Putin's tele-



vised remarks. "They say one thing on television, and in reality it's another. ... People are queuing everywhere," he added, declining to

identify himself out of concern for his safety. An AP count shows over 50 reported attacks by Ukraine on oil refineries, depots, terminals and other oil infrastructure in Russia and the illegally annexed Crimean Peninsula since late March. Often, the same facility is hit more than once -- such as the refinery in the Black Sea town of Tuapse, which was struck four times in just over two weeks. As a result, the amount of crude oil Russia processed into fuel in June was down 25 per cent from a year ago, to 3.95 million barrels per day - the lowest level in over two decades, said Gary Peach, oil markets analyst at Energy Intelligence. (AP)

Pakistan rejects India's remarks about airstrikes on Afghanistan



SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan on Wednesday rejected India's remarks about the deadly airstrikes in Afghanistan, claiming that it had targeted "terrorist infrastructure". Pakistan claimed to have killed more than two dozen militants in strikes in Afghanistan on June 29, after accusing the rebels based in Afghanistan of several attacks inside Pakistan. India on Monday strongly condemned Pakistan's air strikes on Afghan territory in which several civilians were killed, calling them a "blatant act of aggression" and a "direct threat" to regional peace and stability. "It reflects Pakistan's persistent pattern of reckless behaviour and its futile attempt to externalise internal failures through desperate acts of violence beyond its borders," the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said in a statement on Monday. (PTI)

CRIS celebrates its 41st Foundation Day, highlights AI push in Railways

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre for Railway Information Systems (CRIS), the technology arm of the Ministry of Railways, celebrated its 41st Foundation Day on Wednesday, reaffirming its commitment to driving the digital transformation of Indian Railways through advanced information technology and artificial intelligence.

The Foundation Day celebrations were held at the India Habitat Centre in New Delhi and attended by senior officials from the Ministry of Railways, railway executives, industry experts, academicians, and CRIS employees.

Over the past four decades, CRIS has developed and maintained several mission-critical digital platforms that have transformed railway operations and passenger services. These include the Passenger Reservation System (PRS), Freight Operations Information System, Unreserved Ticketing System, National Train Enquiry System, Control Office Application, and the Indian Railways e-Procurement System. The organization said these applications have improved operational efficiency, enhanced customer service, and increased transparency across the railway ecosystem.



As part of its ongoing modernization efforts, CRIS is upgrading several legacy applications using the latest technologies to improve scalability, reliability, and overall system performance.

One of the major milestones highlighted during the event was the success of the RailOne SuperApp, launched on CRIS's 40th Foundation Day last year. Designed as an integrated digital platform for railway passengers, the app has recorded more than 4.35 crore downloads since its launch and currently processes an average of 10 lakh transactions daily.

CRIS also showcased progress in

modernizing the Passenger Reservation System, one of Indian Railways' most critical digital infrastructure projects.

The upgraded system will feature a modern technology stack designed to improve resilience and scalability. Once fully operational, the new PRS will be capable of processing up to 1.25 lakh ticket bookings per minute-five times the current capacity of 25,000 bookings per minute-allowing Indian Railways to handle growing passenger demand more efficiently.

Artificial Intelligence emerged as a key focus area during the celebrations. CRIS said it is integrating AI-

driven solutions across multiple operational domains to improve efficiency, safety, and reliability.

The technology is being deployed for applications such as train path planning, freight flow management, predictive and preventive maintenance, and enhanced passenger services.

The theme of this year's Foundation Day seminar, "Governance in the Age of AI — Transformation from Digital Enterprise to Intelligent Network," reflected the organisation's emphasis on leveraging AI for data-driven governance and informed decision-making.

According to CRIS, these initiatives are being developed in collaboration with industry, academic institutions, and technology partners to support Indian Railways' vision of building a safer, smarter, and more efficient railway network.

Established under the Ministry of Railways, CRIS is responsible for designing, developing, implementing, and maintaining information technology solutions for Indian Railways. Its portfolio of digital platforms supports passenger services, freight operations, logistics, infrastructure management, financial systems, and enterprise operations, making it a key driver of the railways' digital transformation.

NMDC posts record Q1 iron ore production, strengthens outlook for 60 MT FY27 target

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

State-owned mining major NMDC has reported its highest-ever first-quarter iron ore production and sales since its inception, providing a strong start to FY27 and reinforcing its position as India's largest iron ore producer.

The company produced 15.10 million tonnes (MT) of iron ore during the April-June quarter of FY27, registering a 26 per cent year-on-year increase. Iron ore sales stood at 11.75 MT, up 2 per cent compared with the corresponding period last year, driven by sustained domestic demand and improved operational performance across its mining complexes in Chhattisgarh and Karnataka.

NMDC also recorded its best-ever June performance, producing 5.15 MT of iron ore and selling 3.98 MT. The June figures represent year-on-year growth of 44 per cent in production and 11 per cent in sales, reflecting strong operational momentum.

Commenting on the performance, NMDC Chairman and Managing Director Amitava Mukherjee said India's continued investments in infrastructure and manufacturing are supporting robust demand



for iron ore, positioning the company to meet the country's growing raw material requirements.

"Our strongest-ever first quarter reflects the resilience of our operations, the commitment of our employees, and the trust placed in us by the domestic steel industry. As we expand mining capacities, strengthen logistics and modernise our infrastructure, we are steadily advancing towards our long-term aspiration of becoming a global mining powerhouse," Mukherjee said.

The company attributed its record quarterly performance to sustained domestic steel demand, operational efficiencies, and its ongoing efforts to enhance production capacity. Backed by the government's

infrastructure push, NMDC is accelerating its capacity expansion plans through phased mine development, higher production from existing operations, and investments in modern logistics and evacuation infrastructure.

The company said these initiatives are expected to strengthen its production capabilities while ensuring a reliable supply of high-quality iron ore to the domestic steel sector. The strong first-quarter performance has put NMDC on track to achieve its FY27 production target of 60 MT.

The company is also pursuing its long-term goal of expanding annual production capacity to 100 MT, in line with India's growing steel demand and infrastructure development plans.

SK SINHA TAKES CHARGE AS DIRECTOR (FINANCE) OF GAIL

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

GAIL (India) Ltd. has appointed SK Sinha as its Director (Finance), with the senior finance executive assuming charge on Wednesday. Before joining the company's Board of Directors, Sinha served as Executive Director (Finance & Accounts) at GAIL. A qualified Cost and Management Accountant, he has more than three decades of experience in the oil and gas sector, with expertise spanning corporate finance, accounting, investor relations, taxation, treasury operations, budgeting, project evaluation and mergers and acquisitions.

Sinha joined GAIL as a Management Trainee in the Finance and Accounts department in 1994 and has since held several key positions across the



company's finance functions. During his tenure, he has been associated with initiatives aimed at strengthening financial systems, improving corporate governance and compliance, enhancing cost optimisation, and evaluating large-scale investment projects.

He has also played a key role in the company's finance digitisation efforts, including the implementation of SAP-based systems, automation of financial processes and the centralisation of finance operations.

Durlabh Darshan plans 6D virtual spiritual experience centres

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Spiritual technology platform Durlabh Darshan has announced the launch of what it claims are the world's first large-scale 6D immersive spiritual experience centres, using virtual reality (VR) technology to offer devotees a digitally enhanced temple experience. Actor Ashutosh Rana has joined the initiative as its brand ambassador and mentor.

The platform aims to enable devotees to virtually visit some of India's most prominent temples through immersive experiences that recreate temple rituals and surroundings. Besides VR visuals, the 6D technology incorporates environmental elements such as air, water, and fragrance to simulate the atmosphere of the temple.



Announcing the initiative at a press conference in New Delhi, Rana said the platform seeks to bridge spirituality and technology by making temple experiences accessible to devotees regardless of their location.

"Religion has its own science, and science has its own spirituality. Where the two meet, that is Durlabh Darshan. This is the world's first 6D spiritual experience that allows people to connect with

divinity from anywhere," he said.

According to the company, the first phase of the project will feature immersive experiences from 11 prominent temples across the country. The series will begin on July 1 with presentations on "Shri Ram Ki Ayodhya" and "Ujjaini Ke Mahakaal," with Rana narrating the mythology and spiritual significance associated with each destination.

VIT-AP admits 50 rural students under STARS scheme



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

VIT-AP University has admitted 50 meritorious students from economically disadvantaged backgrounds under its STARS (Support the Advancement of Rural Students) Scheme, offering them a 100 per cent waiver of tuition and hostel fees.

The beneficiaries, selected from 26 districts of Andhra Pradesh, secured top ranks in the Intermediate Public Examination (IPE). The initiative aims to ensure that deserving students are not denied higher education

due to financial constraints.

The STARS Scheme, launched by VIT Chancellor G. Viswanathan at VIT Vellore in 2008 and introduced at VIT-AP in 2017, supports academically talented rural students from economically weaker sections.

Vice-Chancellor P. Arulmozhivarman said many of the selected students come from families of daily wage earners, small farmers and domestic workers, adding that the scheme seeks to empower them through quality education and prepare them for leadership roles.

ALIMCO's Deepak Kumar Kanaujia wins 4 medals at UP State Shooting Championship



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Artificial Limbs Manufacturing Corporation of India (ALIMCO), a public sector enterprise under the Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities, has congratulated its employee, Deepak Kumar Kanaujia, for winning one gold and three silver medals at the 49th UP State Shooting Championship.

The championship was held at the Dr Karni Singh Shooting Range in New Delhi, where Kanaujia competed in the SH1 category of para shooting.

He secured the gold medal in the 50-metre Rifle 3 Positions (SH1) event and won silver medals in the 10-metre Standing Rifle (SH1), 10-metre Prone Rifle (SH1), and 50-metre Rifle Prone (SH1) events.

ALIMCO said Kanaujia's performance reflects his dedication, discipline and excellence in para shooting.

The corporation described the achievement as a matter of pride and said it highlights its commitment to promoting an inclusive environment that enables persons with disabilities to excel in sports as well as other fields.

Congratulating Kanaujia, ALIMCO Chairman and Managing Director said his success would inspire aspiring para athletes across the country and expressed confidence that he would continue to bring recognition to both the organisation and the nation through his achievements.

ALIMCO, a Central Public Sector Enterprise under the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment, works towards the empowerment of persons with disabilities and said it remains committed to supporting employees who demonstrate resilience and excellence in their chosen fields.

The Pioneer opens Keralam edition office

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Keralam Legislative Assembly Speaker Thiruvanchoor Radhakrishnan, Keralam Director General of Police (DGP) Ravada A Chandrashekar, IPS, on Wednesday inaugurated The Pioneer's Keralam edition office in the State Capital marking the publication's expansion into the God's own country.

Addressing the gathering, Radhakrishnan said *The Pioneer*, founded in 1865, is the second-oldest English daily in the country and has built a reputation for credibility and journalistic integrity over more than a century. He expressed confidence that the Keralam edition would uphold the newspaper's legacy of responsible journalism.

Speaking on the occasion, Chandrashekar



sought the support of *The Pioneer* in creating public awareness against drug abuse. Referring to the State Police's anti-narcotics campaign, "Thufan", he said the media has a vital role in mobilising public opinion and encouraging community participation in the fight against narcotics.

The event was hosted by Sudhakar Goud Bandi, Chairman and Managing Director of Amogh Publication Networks Pvt. Ltd., the publisher of the Keralam Edition.

Thanking *The Pioneer's* Delhi headquartered management, Bandi said the newspaper would remain committed to fact-based reporting, public-interest journalism and comprehensive coverage of developments in Keralam. M Nagesh Rao Vanshe, Karnataka Congress Committee Vice President, Father Jacob Vadakkal were also present at the inaugural function along with media professionals, public representatives, senior officials and invited guests.

HUDCO concluded 62nd ITEC training programme on leadership skills for women

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Housing and Urban Development Corporation Ltd. (HUDCO) has concluded the 62nd Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation (ITEC) training programme on "Leadership Skills for Women", a two-week capacity-building initiative sponsored by the Ministry of External Affairs.

The programme, held from June 18 to 30 at HUDCO's HSMI Hostel in the Asian Games Village Complex, brought together 24 women professionals from Iraq for training focused



on leadership development, gender equity and institutional capacity building.

According to HUDCO, the programme was designed to strengthen participants' leadership and decision-making abilities while enhancing their understanding of gender inclusion and preparing them to take on

greater responsibilities within their organisations and professional fields.

The valedictory session was attended by HUDCO Chairman and Managing Director Sanjay Kulshrestha, Director (Corporate Planning) M Nagaraj, and Iraq's Chargé d'Affaires, Oday Hatim Mohammed.

DAILY SUDOKU

		1					7
		1	3			9	
7				2	9		
5						6	1
3	2					7	4
8	1	7					2
			8	7			
							6
			4			3	7
2					5		

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction-no maths involved.

SOLUTION (1.7.26)

3	6	7	5	4	1	2	9	8
5	8	4	9	2	6	7	3	1
1	2	9	7	8	3	5	4	6
6	3	2	8	7	4	9	1	5
4	7	1	6	5	9	3	8	2
8	9	5	1	3	2	4	6	7
9	5	8	3	1	7	6	2	4
2	1	3	4	6	5	8	7	9
7	4	6	2	9	8	1	5	3

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

THURSDAY | JULY 2, 2026

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
10							11
13							15
17							
20	21						23
24							
27							28
30							

ACROSS

1 Extent of one's ambitions? (5)
6 What to wear for noisy music? (5)
9 A singularly glassy looking thing (7)
10 Take up physical training after some fuss (5)
11 Swift creation of crude type (5)
12 Yes, Sarah has fibre! (5)
13 Sweet wine will spoil most salad (7)
15 Back us with many an amount of money (3)
17 This lets me out (4)
18 Is able to imitate something tasteful (6)
19 If it's untrue, hiss a politician (5)
20 To fine leg? (6)

DOWN

2 Character crazy to make the most movies? (3,3)
3 The tax I'm to send (6)
4 Totally friendless youngster (3)
5 Her boy gets an excellent rise (5)
6 Being giddy, rush off (7)
7 Genuine fire alarm component (4)
8 Concoct something good in one brilliant stroke (4,2)
12 Tales rewritten in stone (5)
13 Confuse me with ridiculous Reg! (5)
14 Competitor's right to take part in carnivals (5)
15 Wild boast of something afoot? (5)

22 In a rage, you'll find me out to do wrong! (4)
24 A fishy, slippery type (3)
25 What Ron East became (7)
26 A good line sold out (5)
27 He, having returned, is in the lab (5)
28 Good place for a pop group (5)
29 Nominally, he's more wary than zany! (7)
30 Hang up, craftily! (5)
31 One woodenly supporting an artist's views? (5)

16 You need cash to feed one (5)
18 Eric, upset by the sad ending, burst into tears! (5)
19 Academic's companion absorbed in an astronomic system! (7)
21 Smoothly played by the alto, for instance? (6)
22 More than one part of Malaysia? (6)
23 Figures the female's out to be tractable (6)
25 A good deal of sense (5)
26 That of the paste packet? (4)
28 Source of the metal for a gold key? (3)

 BRIEFLY

Mexico fans use homophobic chant against Ecuador in WC



Mexican fans used a chant considered homophobic in the first half of the match against Ecuador in the World Cup round of 32 match. The chant, a one-word slur that means male prostitute in Spanish, usually occurs when the opposing goalkeeper is taking a goal kick. The fans did it at the five minute mark when Hernan Galindez was doing his first goal kick of the match on Tuesday night. It is the second time in the tournament that fans used the chant, which has cost the Mexican Federation several fines by FIFA. The chant originated during a match between Mexico and the United States in an Olympic Games qualifying tournament held in Guadalajara, but it went viral at the 2014 World Cup in Brazil.

There has been a tense atmosphere since before the first whistle. Mexico fans gathered late last night and into the early hours of Tuesday outside of Ecuador's hotel in Mexico City where they used horns, drums, motorcycles and cars, alongside DJ's to make noise for their rivals. The tension between the fan bases reflects a deeper geopolitical rift. Diplomatic relations between the two nations have been severed since April 2024, when Ecuadorian police raided the Mexican embassy in Quito to arrest former Vice President Jorge Glas, who had been granted political asylum there. While Ecuadorian President Daniel Noboa recently expressed a willingness to mend ties, Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum stated last Monday that she would not discuss the matter until after the match concluded. (AP)

Ecuador's Hincapie becomes second player sent off for covering his mouth at WC



Ecuador's Piero Hincapie became the second player to be issued a red card at the World Cup under FIFA's new rule that calls for a player to be sent off for covering their mouth during a confrontational exchange with an opponent. Hincapie was sent off in the 95th minute of Ecuador's 2-0 loss to Mexico Tuesday in the round of 32. He was shown the red card following an exchange with Mexico forward Santi Gimenez. FIFA established the new rule to prevent players from hiding abusive comments to opponents by covering their mouth. Paraguay's Miguel Almiron was the first player to be punished under the new rule when he was sent off in a group stage match against Turkey last week. While Ecuador's tournament is over, Hincapie will be suspended for the team's next international match. (AP)

Iran heads home after heartbreaking WC knockout

GABRIELA AOUN ANGUIERA
■ Tijuana (Mexico)

The Iranian national team left North America on Tuesday, departing from its World Cup home in Mexico following a tournament marked by repeated disagreements with US officials, flashes of athletic brilliance and, ultimately, disappointment over barely missing out on advancing beyond the group stage.

The players return to a homeland still in the grips of an unresolved conflict with Israel and the United States. But their fans say they should be proud. "I think even though they lost, it gave people a sense of hope," said Mohammad Modarres, 38, who traveled from San Diego



to bid the team farewell. **Heartbreak over missed chances** After its three group stage matches ended in draws, Iran's World Cup future depended on either Algeria or Austria winning their match on Saturday. Watching from the lobby of their Tijuana

Mexico ends a 40-year knockout drought

CARLOS RODRIGUEZ
■ Mexico City

The 40-year wait is over. Mexicans had learned to live with defeats in the knockout stages of the World Cup. On seven occasions, El Tri fans were left heartbroken at this stage. Not anymore. Julian Quinones and Raul Jimenez scored within a nine-minute span in the first half and Mexico defeated Ecuador 2-0 on Tuesday night to break a four-decade drought in the knockout stage and progress to the round of 16. Quinones opened the scoring in the 22nd minute and Jimenez added a goal in the 31st for the Mexicans, who had not won a knockout-stage match

since defeating Bulgaria in the round of 16 when they hosted the tournament in 1986. Mexico coach Javier Aguirre was one of the starting midfielders in that team in '86. "It means a lot to me because I am one of those who could not progress in the knockout stage," Aguirre said. "We are in the round of 16 and it is happening a great connection with the fans. We are like a family. It is spectacular." Mexico lost seven consecutive times at that same stage from 1994 to 2018 and didn't advance past the group stage in 2022. Aguirre, who returned as Mexico's head coach in August of 2024, was an assistant in 1994 and was the



coach in 2002 and 2010. "We will be on high alert from here until Sunday. We will try to have the players recover from this and we will see if we are able to win again," Aguirre said. For Quinones, it was a third goal in the tournament

and he is now El Tri's second-highest scorer in World Cup history behind Luis "Matador" Hernandez and Javier "Chicharito" Hernandez, who scored four each. Quinones, who was the scoring leader in the Saudi Pro League last season,

has become the spark in the attack that Mexico lacked in previous World Cups. "I am just happy with the result, that is all that matters now," said Quinones, who is playing in his first World Cup with Mexico. The 29-year-old forward arrived in the country from Colombia at age 17 and became a naturalized citizen in 2023. "Life is about struggle and fight until you get what you want," he said, "and I am taking full advantage of the opportunity that I got." Jimenez scored his second goal of the tournament and has 47 with the national team to break a tie with Jared Borgetti. He is five away from tying "Chicharito" Hernandez as

the all-time leading scorer for Mexico. Mexico will play another home match Sunday against the winner of Wednesday's match between England and Congo. Playing at the iconic Azteca Stadium, the Mexican squad boasts an undefeated record across 10 World Cup matches. Mexico has just two official losses at the venue - the last being a World Cup qualifying defeat to Honduras on Sept. 6, 2013. With the win, Mexico extended its unbeaten run to 12 games, dating back to a friendly loss against Paraguay in November. Mexico also became the first CONCACAF side to eliminate a team from CONMEBOL in a World Cup knockout match. (AP)

Ecuador coach steps down after WC exit

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Mexico City

Sebastian Beccacece has stepped down as coach of Ecuador following World Cup elimination. The 45-year-old Argentine confirmed it after Tuesday night's 2-0 defeat to host Mexico. "My contract has to end with the end of the World Cup. For us, we are leaving now," Beccacece said. "I believe the dressing room is full of brotherhood. I'm taking the love, respect, commitment and admiration from the boys, from this group of warriors, the Ecuadorian national team." Beccacece was in charge for two years. He led Ecuador, which was making its fifth World Cup appearance, to the knockout round for just the second time



after a memorable win over four-time champion Germany in the group stage. After that match, Beccacece made a beeline for the stands and climbed up from the field to embrace his wife and other loved ones while yellow-clad fans around him patted him on the back and tens of thousands more around the stadium jumped and

cheered. "When we started this journey there wasn't much hope, there wasn't much of an expectation of us getting here. But we made it, we exceeded certain expectations," Beccacece said. "But we couldn't match the feat." First-half goals from Mexico's Julian Quinones and Raul Jimenez ended Ecuador's tournament run.

FIFA explains WC ruling that led to disallowed controversial Germany goal

JAMES ROBSON ■ Atlanta

FIFA explained the tighter regulations that resulted in Germany having a potentially game-winning goal disallowed in its shock elimination from the World Cup. Defender Jonathan Tah's headed goal in extra time against Paraguay on Monday was ruled out after a video review because of a foul on goalkeeper Orlando Gill. Replays showed Germany's Waldemar Anton push Gill to the ground, but the minimal contact led to criticism of the decision. Germany went on to lose the round of 32 game in a penalty shootout, with Tah firing a decisive spot kick over the bar. FIFA's referees chief Pierluigi Collina said



officials had been told to punish incidents when players try to block opponents and make no attempt to play the ball, especially where goalkeepers are concerned. "Although keeping a position is not a foul per se, when an attacking player is

not interested in the ball and deliberately moves, even marginally, with the clear intention of obstructing opponents' movement and prevents him from defending, then referees, and VAR when needed, should analyze incident and intervene," Collina said. (AP)

France beats Sweden, Mbappe scores twice to tie Messi

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ East Rutherford

Kylian Mbappe felt the heat and turned up the temperature on Lionel Messi in the race for the most goals at the World Cup this year and in the tournament's history. Thriving on a hot, humid afternoon, Mbappe scored his 17th and 18th career World Cup goals in France's 3-0 rout of Sweden on Tuesday, moving one back of Messi's record of 19. With six in the tournament, Mbappe tied the Argentina star in the race for the Golden Boot. Asked coming off the field if he was already looking forward to facing Paraguay,

Mbappe quipped, "I'm looking forward to the changing room and the AC." It was 90 degrees Fahrenheit (32 degrees Celsius) for the 5 p.m. kickoff, so steamy that Lucas Digne let himself be doused by a sprinkler during the first-half hydration break. Before halftime, Mbappe scored one for the highlight reel. In the 45th minute, Mbappe engaged in a give-and-go with Ousmane Dembele, crossed over Viktor Gyokeres and fired his shot past goalkeeper Jacob Widell Zetterstrom. "It goes without saying that Mapp is an absolute top, top player," Sweden coach Graham Potter said.



"His goal was a fine example of the speed and the change of direction and the way he can get the shot off quick. It's an incredibly high level." That broke a tie with Brazilian greats Leonidas and

Ronaldo for the most goals in the knockout stage of the World Cup with nine. Mbappe added to his record with his 10th, scoring in the 74th minute off a feed from Michael Olise. Celebrating

the first goal, Mbappe ran immediately to coach Didier Deschamps after scoring. This was Deschamps' first game back on the sideline after missing the group stage finale to fly back to Europe for his mother's funeral. "We know that the head coach had to face a really tough, tough challenge," Mbappe said. "Everyone will go through that one day. It goes beyond football. He knows that he will never be alone with us, and we will support him." With 18 goals in 18 World Cup games, Mbappe has scored at an even faster clip than Messi, who has played in 29 games at the tournament.

Deschamps bowed to Mbappe when he was substituted out in the 85th minute. That kept Mbappe from chasing a hat trick, but he also could have scored in the 32nd minute. Instead, the 27-year-old banged a shot off the left post and even began to celebrate before watching it bounce back. Scoring twice later allowed Mbappe not to regret that missed opportunity at a World Cup he is trying to soak in while playing some of his best soccer. "I did say that I wanted to enjoy this World Cup to the fullest," Mbappe said. "I'm not saying that the other World Cup I didn't enjoy, but I was younger.

Haaland scores decisive goal for Norway

STEPHEN HAWKINS ■ Arlington

Erling Haaland scored the deciding goal in the 86th minute and Norway won a knockout game at the World Cup for the first time, advancing to the round of 16 with a 2-1 victory over Ivory Coast on Tuesday. Three defenders converged on Patrick Berg as he moved into the penalty area with the ball. He kicked it over to a wide-open Haaland, who scored his fifth goal in three games at this year's tournament. Antonio Nusa scored in the first half with a curling kick for Norway, which is in its fourth World Cup and will next play five-time champion Brazil in the round of 16 on Sunday at MetLife



Stadium in East Rutherford, New Jersey. The match comes 28 years after what many considered the greatest win ever for the Norwegians against Brazil. Norway is playing in its first World Cup since that 1998 appearance, when the team got to the knockout

round only after scoring goals in the 83rd and 89th minutes for an incredible 2-1 comeback win over then-reigning World Cup champion Brazil in the group finale. Amad Diallo, who had kept Norway from taking a two-goal lead earlier in the second half, evened the

match for Ivory Coast with a left-footed kick in the 74th minute. After Haaland's goal, his Norway-record 60th in 53 matches, Ivory Coast kept pressing and had a chance to equalize with a direct free kick by Diallo in the sixth minute of stoppage time. Orjan Nyland made a leaping stop, the last of his four saves, when he deflected the ball away as he extended his left hand across his body. Haaland, who won the Golden Boot in the Premier League last season with 27 goals for Manchester City, has scored in 13 straight competitive international games — a total of 25 goals in that span. The Elephants, ranked 31st by FIFA, had never before won twice in the same World Cup. (AP)

Penalty shootouts at the World Cup are a drama of inhumane pressure

JIM VERTUNO ■ New York

The World Cup is in the lose-and-go-home stage of the tournament and the pressure keeps rising with every minute of every match. **The biggest pressure cooker of them all:** The penalty kick shootout. Exhausted players and goalkeepers face off in a tense one-on-one confrontation that carries the hopes and dreams of entire nations. Two of the first four matches in the round of 32 were settled by shootouts: Morocco beat the Netherlands and Paraguay bested Germany. A miss can mean humiliation. A goalkeeper's save or

the final bulge of the ball in the back of the net can bring tears of joy to millions. That kind of pressure can reach "inhumane" levels, almost all of it focused on the penalty takers, said Geir Jordet, a professor at the Norwegian School of Sport Sciences and author of the book, "Pressure: Lessons from the Psychology of the Penalty Shootout." "In our research, the only emotion everyone agrees is present is anxiety," Jordet said. Expect more shootouts, more pressure, more anxiety. A record five games at the 2022 World Cup in Qatar were settled by penalty kicks, including the final when Argentina beat France. "As

you go into knockout football it's something that becomes more prominent in the games," England winger Noni Madueke said. "So like every part of our game we want to be at the highest level when it comes to that." The physical and mental distance from spot to goal This tense battle of wills is fought over a 12-yard (11-metre) distance between the penalty spot and the goal line. The shootout was added to the game in 1970 and has settled several of the world's biggest tournaments. The first World Cup final to be settled by penalty kicks was Brazil's 1994 victory over Italy. That shootout also produced one of the most infam-



mous misses in soccer history when Italy great Roberto Baggio sent the final kick over the crossbar. **The penalty taker Techniques vary:** Some take the kick quickly. Others pause, taking deep, calming breaths before

they approach. Some run and strike it hard. A popular variation is the stutter-step, waiting for the goalkeeper to commit to which way he's going. The penalty taker faces the most pressure in the moment because he's expect-

ed to score, Jordet told The Associated Press by email. Research shows that the players who start toward the ball almost immediately after the referee's whistle more often miss than those who wait between two and five seconds, he said. "We suspect this is because those who (wait) extremely short sometimes do so because they, understandably, just want to get this stressful situation done and over with," Jordet said. It takes guts to be in that moment, United States forward Christian Pulisic said. "For the people that go up and shoot, it takes a lot of courage. It's not easy," Pulisic said. "Goalkeepers get better

and better every single year." **The view from goal:** Standing between the posts, goalkeepers have three basic choices. Dive left, dive right or stay in the middle in a guessing game of anticipation. Morocco keeper Yassine Bounou did something critically different. On the decisive save against the Netherlands, he moved to his right while standing up. By staying upright, Bounou used his left hand to easily swat away the kick from Crysencio Summerville, who was shooting for the upper corner. Had Bounou dived, the ball would have easily found the net. The best goalkeepers are "creative, deliberate and volatile" in their

attempts to disrupt the shooter, Jordet said. Tactics can include throwing the ball away, verbal insults and physical confrontation at the penalty spot. The mind games can get so hostile they can result in a yellow card for the goalkeeper. He noted Bounou's well-timed body twitches and hand fakes to disrupt shooters' timing. The "master" of the mind games, Jordet said, is Argentina keeper Emiliano Martinez, who has won his last six penalty shootouts, including the 2022 World Cup final. "I would say everyone's different, every keeper's different, everyone's got their own routines," said England goalkeeper Jordan Pickford. (AP)



24 teams to feature in Durand Cup starting July 25

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kolkata

The Durand Cup football tournament this year will feature 24 teams, including seven debutants, with matches to be played across five cities from July 25 to August 23. The tournament begins in Kolkata on July 25 before it is played in Ranchi, Imphal, Shillong and Guwahati over the next four weeks. The final will be held at the Vivekananda Yuba Bharati Krirangan in Kolkata. The competition will once again bring together Indian Super League clubs, I-League sides, Services teams, emerging domestic outfits and overseas teams. Among the seven debutants are

Defenders FC of the Sri Lankan Armed Forces and Meghalaya Premier League champions Nongkseh Sports, Social and Cultural Club (SS&CC). Kolkata will once again serve as the tournament's hub, hosting two groups, the opening match, two quarter-finals, one semi-final and the final across the Vivekananda Yuba Bharati Krirangan and Kishore Bharati Krirangan. The city will play host to record 17-time

THE TOURNAMENT WILL INCLUDE SEVEN DEBUTANTS, MATCHES WILL BE PLAYED ACROSS FIVE CITIES



champions Mohun Bagan Super Giant, 16-time winners East Bengal FC, Mohammedan SC, South United FC, CISF, Indian Army and debutants Baghpatt FC and Samaleswari Sporting. Ranchi will make its debut as a Durand Cup host, with the Birs Munda Stadium staging league matches from July 26 to August 16 and one quarter-final. The city will host Jamshedpur FC, Sporting Club Delhi, Indian Air Force and debutants Defenders FC, Imphal's

Khumam Lampak Stadium will host league matches from July 28 to August 17, besides a quarter-final. The group features local clubs TRAU FC and NEROCA FC, Indian Navy and debutants FC Raengdai. Shillong's Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium will stage league matches from July 31 to August 20 before hosting one of the semi-finals. The venue will feature Shillong Lajong FC, Nongkseh SS&CC, Langsons FC and debutants Mumbai FC. The Indira Gandhi Athletic Stadium in Guwahati will host league-stage fixtures from August 1 to 13. Defending champions NorthEast United FC headline the group, alongside FC1, Bodoland FC and Karbi Anglong Morning Star FC.

Entrepreneur's wanderlust fuels marathon firsts for India



HIMANK NEGI ■ New Delhi

Ram Gopal Kothari insists he is not a runner but a traveller. And his insatiable hunger to explore has taken the Kolkata entrepreneur from the North Pole to one of the world's most remote inhabited islands, Rapa Nui in Chile, where he became the first Indian to complete the Volcano Marathon. Less than a year after becoming the first Indian to complete a marathon at the Geographic North Pole, the 45-year-old Kothari has scripted another first, this time on Rapa Nui, also called the Easter Island, famed for its mysterious Moai statues and dramatic volcanic landscape. The journey involved travelling more than 24,000 kilometres from India. It was also the 80th country that Kothari set foot on in his eventful life. "I have become the first Indian to complete the Volcano Marathon on Rapa Nui (Easter Island), Chile, one of the world's most remote inhabited islands. The journey involved travelling over 24,000 kilometres from India via Mumbai, Istanbul and Santiago before reaching Rapa Nui..." he told PTI in an interview. "As with my previous expedition, this journey was about

pushing the boundaries of endurance and inspiring others to dream beyond limits," he added. The records are, however, merely significant milestones in a much larger journey. "You used the right word, hunger. Now, it has become a little like hunger," he said when asked what keeps drawing him to some of the world's most unusual marathons. That hunger first took him to Antarctica in 2022. While travelling there, he became fascinated by the idea of visiting the Geographic North Pole and stumbled upon a marathon organised in the Arctic. The original event was held at 89 degrees North before participants were flown to the Pole by helicopter. When organisers later introduced a format that staged the race directly at 90 degrees North, Kothari signed up and became the first Indian to complete the event. But another destination still remained to be checked in his bucket list. "Easter Island was one of my dream places. So, I had to go to Easter Island one day because I was seeing Easter Island for a long time. There are statues of Moai. Nobody knows who installed them," he said excitedly. (PTI)



England feels like second home: Pujara after MCC honour

BHARAT SHARMA ■ New Delhi

Standout performances of Cheteshwar Pujara's exemplary Test career came in Australia but the former India number three, who was recently honoured with the MCC life membership, says he only got the home away from home feeling in England. Having toured with the Indian team thrice and played for multiple teams in county cricket, Pujara has spent the most amount of time outside Rajkot driving across the length and breadth of England. Now bestowed with the honorary life membership of Marylebone Cricket Club (MCC), the owner of the fabled Lord's stadium, Pujara has another reason to visit the "Home of Cricket". "I've

played a lot of county cricket in the UK. So when you end up playing a lot of cricket over there, you feel like you're at home. And for me, it's a great pleasure and privilege to be part of the MCC. "And getting this honorary membership, it means a lot. As a cricketer, when you have worked hard throughout your career and when that effort is recognised, you feel proud about your achievements as a cricketer," the 38-year-old told in an interview. In the three Test matches he was part of at Lord's, India won two. He could not get a hundred at the iconic venue for his national team but he looks back fondly at his double hundred for Sussex at a ground steeped in history. Pujara, a veteran of 103 Tests, has played at all famous grounds around the world but there is something different about turning up at Lord's. "So I've got some fond memories of being at Lord's, playing cricket, also watching cricket there. When I had my second ACL reconstruction, that was in 2011, when I was playing for RCB and I got injured. And then my knee surgery was actually in London," he said. (PTI)

Dinsara to lead Sri Lanka U-19 vs India



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Vimath Dinsara will lead the Sri Lanka Under-19 team in the upcoming home series against India Under-19 with Kavaveeja Gamage named its vice-captain. The tour will feature a three-match one-day series and a two-match four-day series. The one-day matches will be played in Hambantota on July 4, 6 and 9, while the four-day matches will begin in Galle from July 13 and in Colombo from July 20. The one-day squad features promising young talent from across the country. Wicketkeepers Chamarindu Nethsara and Jason Fernando have also been included in the squad alongside skipper Dinsara and deputy Gamage.

Ishan Kishan pips Abhishek to top T20I batting charts

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dubai

Dashing India wicketkeeper-batter Ishan Kishan has displaced teammate Abhishek Sharma from the top spot in the latest ICC men's T20I batting rankings released on Wednesday. The rise to the top for Kishan (876 ranking points) comes on the back of his consistent form at the T20 World Cup at the start of the year, where the flamboyant southpaw compiled 317 runs at a strike rate of almost 200 that included an Player of the Match performance against Pakistan in Colombo. Abhishek (869 ranking points) had held the top ranking for almost 12 months, with Kishan joining an exclusive group that includes



Virat Kohli and Suryakumar Yadav as one of four male players from India to have held the premier position for batters in T20I cricket. Pakistan's Sahibzada Farhan is a distant third in the list with 848 points. In the latest list, newly appointed India vice-captain Tilak Varma (747 rating points) is static at sixth place where as sacked former skipper Suryakumar Yadav is eighth in the list having dropped a slot.



Despite loss Serena Williams enjoys comeback at 44

ANDREW DAMPF ■ London

The roars began even before Serena Williams stepped on Centre Court. Then they grew louder when the 23-time Grand Slam champion arrived to play her first singles match in nearly four years. And when it was all over and the 44-year-old Williams had performed admirably in a three-set defeat to an opponent less than half her age in the opening round of Wimbledon with her two daughters cheering her on, Williams smiled as she walked off to a loud round of applause. "It was really great to be back at Wimbledon. I never expected to be here," Williams said in a statement released by Wimbledon organizers. "The atmosphere was amazing. Walking out was amazing. I definitely relished it and missed it and enjoyed the moment more than anything." In a 6-3, 6-7 (6), 6-3 loss to 20-year-old Maya Joint of Australia on Tuesday, Williams showed she can still crank out serves faster than 120 mph and dictate points with her heavy groundstrokes. (AP)

I had the belief to beat Serena: Maya

KEN MAGUIRE ■ London

When Serena Williams accepted an offer to play singles at Wimbledon, Maya Joint got to thinking. The 20-year-old Joint had said there was "always a part of me that wanted to experience playing against her." After getting what she wished for - a first-round meeting with the tennis icon -



Joint delivered on the biggest stage. The Michigan-born Australian showed few nerves in winning the biggest match of her life - defeating Williams 6-3, 6-7 (6), 6-3 on Tuesday to spoil the 44-year-old Williams' singles comeback at the All England Club. "I didn't get much sleep last night. I was up until like 2 a.m. just thinking about it," Joint said in her on-court interview. The 87th-ranked Joint certainly looked calm on the outside

but said she had serious butterflies walking onto Centre Court alongside the GOAT of women's tennis. During warmups, she felt like her legs "weren't moving." "I really don't know how I got a pretty good start in the match," Joint said. "She has such an aura, she's just a legend and this court has so many huge names that have played on it. I've been dreaming about this moment since I was a little kid, so this is pretty crazy." Joint notched her first Wimbledon singles win and just her third Grand Slam singles victory. (AP)

Achutaditya and Arjun make first-round exit from Canada Open

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Markham (Canada)

India's men's doubles pair of Achutaditya Rao Doddavarapu and Pochana Arjun suffered a first round exit from the Canada Open badminton tournament here after losing in straight games here. The Indian duo went down 9-21, 7-21 to fifth-seeded home pair Kevin Lee and Ty Alexander Lindeman in just 23 minutes in the opening round of the BWF Super 300 event on Tuesday night. India's campaign will gather pace on Wednesday with fourth seed Kidambi Srikanth opening his men's singles campaign against Malaysia's Paris Olympics bronze medalist Lee Zii Jia. Aakarshi Kashyap Devika Sihag, Annol Kharb Tharun Mannepalli, Saneeth Dayanand and Tanya Hemanth will also begin their respective campaigns.



Medal assured for Abhinandh and Bhowmick at Asian Youth TT



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bangkok

India's top-seeded U-19 mixed doubles pair of PB Abhinandh and Divyanshi Bhowmick moved to the semifinal after producing a sensational victory over the Chinese combination at the Asian Youth Table Tennis Championships here on Wednesday. With the emphatic 11-9, 11-6, 11-7 quarterfinal triumph, the Indian pair has not only secured a place in the last four but also assured the country of at least a bronze medal in the prestigious continental championships.

Abhinandh and Divyanshi displayed remarkable composure and tactical discipline to outplay Yiren Tang and Yiwei Jiang of China. The victory underlined the growing stature of the Indian pair, who entered the championships as the top seeds and have so far lived up to that billing with a string of commanding performances. Earlier in the competition, the Indian duo had comfortably negotiated their Round of 16 encounter, booking their place in the quarterfinals.

Shelton stunned at Wimbledon with 1st-round loss

KEN MAGUIRE ■ London

Ben Shelton wasted a match point in the fifth-set tiebreaker against qualifier Otto Virtanen at Wimbledon in what the fourth-seeded American called "one of the toughest losses of my career." Shelton was eliminated 6-4, 3-6, 6-7 (8), 6-2, 7-6 (9) on Tuesday, losing in the first round at the grass-court Grand Slam for the first time in his young career. The 23-year-old Shelton led 8-5 in the deciding 10-point tiebreaker against his 140th-ranked opponent and had match point at 9-8 but made an unforced error and then lost the next two points. "I thought I put myself in a great position to win at the end. He came up with the goods," said Shelton, who reached the quarterfinals last year at the All England Club. The left-handed American said he "wasn't getting many free points." "The way that he was playing, hitting the ball, it definitely forced my hand. He's playing aggressive," Shelton said. "He wasn't really making any mistakes. Towards the end, any ball I left



semi-hanging, he was ripping a winner, especially in that last game before the tiebreak. "In the tiebreak," he continued, "I was trying to get to the net as much as I could, try to really rush him and not

allow him to swing away from the baseline." The 25-year-old Virtanen came through the qualifying tournament and earned the biggest win of his career in eliminating Shelton, who is ranked No. 5. (AP)